Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 6 · DAYS 117-149

The Mosaic Covenant II: Tabernacle and Holiness

Exodus 25-40, Leviticus

God designs a way to dwell among his people. Holiness, sacrifice, and mediation.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it for you on the altar to make atonement for your souls."

LEVITICUS 17:11

Who may approach a holy God: Psalms 15, 24, 51, 50, 40, 91, and 92.

UNIT 6

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DAY 117 · WEEK 17

Exodus 25:1-26:37

The Tabernacle design begins, ark, table, lampstand

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 25:1-26:37. These chapters are a set of building instructions, so read them slowly and let your imagination build the structure as you go. Notice that the first piece of furniture described is the ark, not the courtyard or the outer tent. God starts from the center and works outward.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses is on Mount Sinai with God, and the covenant has just been sealed (Exodus 24). Now God gives him a pattern for a tent that Israel is to build, so that the God who met them on the mountain can live in their midst. The tabernacle is a portable sanctuary, and it will travel with Israel through the wilderness. The instructions run from Exodus 25 to 31, and the building itself is told in Exodus 35 to 40. The whole project answers one question: how can a holy God live among a sinful people?

STEP 3

Observation

1. The offering for the tabernacle is voluntary, from “every man whose heart moves him” (25:2).
2. The purpose is stated: “And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst” (25:8).
3. Moses is told to make everything “according to the pattern” he was shown on the mountain (25:9, 40).
4. The ark of the covenant is a gold-covered chest with a lid called the mercy seat, and two cherubim face each other over it (25:10-22).
5. God says, “There I will meet with you” above the mercy seat (25:22).

6. The ark holds “the testimony,” the tablets of the law (25:16, 21).
7. The table of the bread of the Presence (25:23-30) and the lampstand shaped like a flowering almond tree (25:31-40) fill the holy place.
8. The tabernacle is made of curtains of blue, purple, and scarlet with cherubim woven into them, and a veil separates the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place (26:31-33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to notice is the purpose. God does not ask for a building because he needs a house. He asks for it because he wants to be near his people. “That I may dwell in their midst” is the whole point. The tabernacle is a statement that the God who thundered from the mountain intends to live in a tent among them.

The second thing to notice is the order. The ark comes first, and it holds the tablets of the law. Over it is the mercy seat, the lid, and between the cherubim God says he will speak. The law is under the throne, and mercy is on top of the law. When the high priest later sprinkles blood on the mercy seat on the Day of Atonement, the picture will be complete: the demands of the law are met by a sacrifice, and the way is open for God to meet with sinners.

The third thing is the language of Eden. The tabernacle is full of garden imagery. The lampstand is a tree with branches, buds, and almond blossoms. The cherubim recall the guardians placed at the east of Eden (Genesis 3:24). The fabric of the tabernacle has pictures of cherubim on it. The entrance to the sanctuary faces east, just like Eden. The tabernacle is a small Eden, a place where God and people may meet again. What was lost in Genesis 3 is being slowly restored.

The fourth thing is the layers of holiness. Gold, blue, and purple become richer the closer you get to the center. The veil marks a boundary that only one man can cross, once a year. The building teaches that God is near, and that his nearness is dangerous to sinners unless a way is made. The next few weeks of reading will explain what that way is.

Finally, notice the phrase “according to the pattern.” Moses is not free to design the tabernacle however he likes. This is the first clue that the earthly tabernacle is a copy of something heavenly, a point the letter to the Hebrews will make.

STEP 5

Connection

John says that the Word became flesh and “dwelt among us” (John 1:14). The Greek word means “tabernacled.” Jesus is the true dwelling place of God with man. Hebrews 8:5 says that the priests serve “a copy and shadow of the heavenly things,” quoting the instruction to make

everything according to the pattern. Revelation 21:3 promises, “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.”

STEP 6

Application

Think about the first purpose of the tabernacle: God wanted to be near his people. Spend a few minutes thanking God that he wants to be with you, and not just to rule you.

Notice that the offering was voluntary and from the heart. Ask yourself whether your giving to God, of time and money, comes from a willing heart.

Remember that in Christ your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 6:19). Ask God to help you live as someone in whom he dwells.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he chose to live among his people.
- Ask him to make you a willing giver.
- Thank him that in Christ he has come even closer.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

“And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst.”

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 118 · WEEK 17

Exodus 27:1-28:43

The altar, the court, the priestly garments

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 27:1-28:43. Yesterday took you inside the tent. Today takes you to the courtyard and to the clothes of the priests. As you read the description of the altar and the garments, ask what each one says about how a sinner can come near to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The instructions for the tabernacle continue. Chapter 27 describes the bronze altar of burnt offering, which stands at the entrance, and the surrounding courtyard. Chapter 28 turns from the building to the people who will serve in it. Aaron and his sons are chosen as priests, and God gives detailed instructions for their garments. These are not ordinary clothes. They are "for glory and for beauty" (28:2), and each piece carries meaning.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The altar of burnt offering is made of acacia wood covered with bronze, with horns at its four corners (27:1-8).
2. The courtyard is enclosed by linen curtains, so that the people see the altar before they see the tent (27:9-19).
3. The lamp is to burn "from evening to morning before the LORD" as a perpetual statute (27:20-21).
4. Aaron and his sons are "brought near" from among the people of Israel to serve as priests (28:1).
5. The high priest wears an ephod with two onyx stones, each engraved with the names of six tribes (28:9-12).

6. The breastpiece has twelve stones with the names of the twelve tribes, and Aaron is to bear them "on his heart" when he enters the Holy Place (28:15-21, 29).
7. On the turban is a plate of pure gold engraved "Holy to the LORD" (28:36).
8. Aaron bears "any guilt from the holy things that the people of Israel consecrate" (28:38).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The order of the building teaches something. To approach the tabernacle, a worshiper had to pass through the gate and meet the bronze altar first. Before anyone could draw near to God, a sacrifice had to be made. The altar stood directly in the way. There was no path around it. The first lesson of the tabernacle is that sinners come to God by way of a substitute.

The second lesson is the role of the priest. Notice that Aaron is "brought near" (28:1), which means he was chosen, not self-appointed. No one can walk into God's presence on his own. A mediator is needed, and God provides one. Every piece of the priest's clothing speaks of his task. The ephod and breastpiece carry the names of the twelve tribes, on his shoulders and on his heart. He represents the people before God, with their weight on his shoulders and their names near his heart.

The gold plate on the turban says "Holy to the LORD." It is a remarkable detail. The priest is himself a sinner, and the people's offerings are imperfect. Yet verse 38 says that Aaron bears "any guilt" connected with their gifts. The plate on his forehead is a sign that even the best worship of sinners needs to be covered. This is humbling. Even our worship is not good enough without a mediator.

Finally, notice the "glory and beauty" of the clothing. The gold, blue, purple, and scarlet threads are the same colors as the tabernacle curtains. The priest is dressed like the building. This shows that the priest belongs to the sanctuary. It also shows that God's holiness is beautiful and not only fearsome. He is not a harsh master but a God of glory, and he wants his people to see it.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews tells you that Jesus is the great high priest who has passed through the heavens (Hebrews 4:14), who "always lives to make intercession" for us (Hebrews 7:25). Unlike Aaron, he has no sin of his own to cover (Hebrews 7:27). Peter says that all believers are now "a royal priesthood" (1 Peter 2:9). The altar finds its fulfillment at the cross, where Jesus offered himself once for all (Hebrews 10:10).

STEP 6

Application

Praise God for your mediator. Picture Jesus carrying your name on his shoulders and over his heart, as Aaron did for Israel.

If you tend to think that your prayers and worship need to be perfect before God will receive them, remember the gold plate. He receives them because of the priest, not because of you.

Ask God to help you serve others as a priest, by praying for them and bringing their needs before him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for carrying you on his shoulders and on his heart.
- Ask him to teach you to pray for others as he prays for you.
- Thank him that your worship is received because of him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 119 · WEEK 17

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Exodus 25:8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

EXODUS 25:8

REST

Meditation

Exodus 25:8 is the heart of the tabernacle instructions. It is easy to lose it among the details of cubits and curtains, so give it a day to rest in your mind.

"Let them make me a sanctuary." The word "sanctuary" means a holy place, a place set apart. God is not asking for an ordinary building. He is asking for a place where the holy can meet the human.

"That I may dwell." This is the purpose clause. The God who made heaven and earth wants to live among his creatures. The verb is the root of the word "tabernacle" and of the Hebrew term shekinah, which later Jewish writers used for the presence of God. The whole Bible will keep returning to this theme: God wants to be with us.

"In their midst." The tabernacle was placed at the very center of the camp, with the tribes arranged around it on every side. God did not set himself apart on the edge. He lived in the middle of his people.

For the Christian, the verse points forward to Jesus, who “dwelt among us” (John 1:14), and to the church, which is “a holy temple in the Lord” and “a dwelling place for God by the Spirit” (Ephesians 2:21-22). It points forward as well to the day when “the dwelling place of God is with man” forever (Revelation 21:3).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you left the covenant at Sinai and began to read the instructions for the tabernacle. You saw the ark and the mercy seat, the table, the lampstand, and the curtains and veil of the tent. You saw the bronze altar and the courtyard, and you read about the garments of the priests, including the breastpiece with the names of the twelve tribes. The pattern is clear: God wants to dwell among his people, and he provides both a place and a mediator to make it possible. The week taught that approach to God is always by way of a sacrifice and a priest.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The tabernacle had a gate, an altar, a veil, and a priest between God and the people. What does this teach you about the way to approach a holy God?

How is Jesus the true tabernacle and the true high priest? What difference does it make that the veil is torn and you can come near through him?

Where in your daily life do you most need to remember that God is near and wants to be with you? Write a short prayer asking him to make his presence real to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for making his home with his people.

Rest in his nearness today.

Ask him to help you carry that nearness into the week.

DAY 120 · WEEK 18

Exodus 29:1-46

Ordination of the priests, mediation established

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 29:1-46. This chapter describes the ceremony that sets Aaron and his sons apart as priests. It involves blood, ashes, and many animals, so read it slowly and ask what it says about how a person is made fit to serve a holy God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 28 described the priests' clothing. Chapter 29 describes their ordination. It is a seven-day ceremony, and Leviticus 8 will tell how it was carried out. The rite involves washing, clothing, anointing, sacrifices, and the application of blood to the priests' bodies. The point is that no one, not even Aaron, can serve in God's presence simply because he wants to. He must be cleansed and consecrated by God's own provision.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The priests are washed with water at the entrance of the tent and then dressed in their garments (29:4-9).
2. Aaron and his sons lay their hands on the head of a bull, which is killed as a sin offering (29:10-14).
3. They lay their hands on a ram for a burnt offering, "a pleasing aroma, a food offering to the LORD" (29:15-18).
4. Blood from the second ram is put on the right ear, right thumb, and right big toe of Aaron and his sons (29:19-21).
5. The priests are sprinkled with anointing oil mixed with blood (29:21).

6. The ordination lasts for seven days, with a sin offering each day for atonement (29:35-37).
7. The daily offering of a lamb each morning and evening is described (29:38-42).
8. God promises, "I will dwell among the people of Israel and will be their God" (29:45).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The ordination ceremony shows that the priests' fitness for service is entirely a matter of God's provision. Aaron does not earn the right. First he is washed. Then he is clothed. Then he is anointed. Then sacrifices are offered on his behalf, and he places his hands on the animals to identify himself with them. The priest is cleansed before he is allowed to cleanse others.

The laying on of hands is worth noticing. It is a sign of identification. When Aaron places his hands on the bull, the animal stands in his place. It is not a magic act. It is a picture of substitution: the animal's life is given instead of the sinner's. This is the first time you see this in detail, and you will see it again in Leviticus.

The blood on the ear, thumb, and toe is a striking detail. The priest's hearing, his working hand, and his walking foot are all marked. It is a picture of a whole person given to God, set apart from head to toe for God's service. The priest hears God's word, does God's work, and walks in God's ways because blood has been applied to him.

The chapter ends with the promise that is the true goal of the whole system: "I will dwell among the people of Israel and will be their God. And they shall know that I am the LORD their God, who brought them out of the land of Egypt that I might dwell among them" (29:45-46). The exodus was for this. God did not just release Israel from slavery. He brought them out so that he could live with them. The sacrifices, the clothes, and the priests are the means. His presence is the end.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews contrasts the priests of the old covenant with Jesus. They were appointed "without an oath," and they were prevented by death from continuing, but Jesus is a priest forever (Hebrews 7:20-24). Peter says that believers are "a holy priesthood" (1 Peter 2:5), and the cleansing that makes this possible is Jesus' blood (Hebrews 9:13-14). John writes that Jesus "made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father" (Revelation 1:6).

STEP 6

Application

Remember that you do not serve God because you are fit. You serve because you have been washed and clothed. Take that as encouragement if you feel unworthy.

Notice the ear, hand, and foot. Ask God to set apart what you listen to, what you do, and where you go for his glory.

Pray for pastors and ministry leaders you know, that they would serve out of grace and not out of pride.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for washing you and making you fit to serve.
- Offer him your ears, hands, and feet, and tell him what you mean by it.
- Ask him to make your whole life an offering.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 121 · WEEK 18

Exodus 30:1-31:18

The altar of incense, anointing oil, bronze basin, the Sabbath

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 30:1-31:18. Today's reading finishes the instructions for the tabernacle with several smaller items and ends with a reminder about the Sabbath. Watch for the repeated theme of consecration, and notice how the Sabbath fits into the story.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

God has described the ark, the table, the lampstand, the tent, the altar, and the priests. Chapter 30 adds a few more items: the altar of incense, a half-shekel census tax for atonement, the bronze basin for washing, the anointing oil, and the incense. Chapter 31 names the craftsmen, Bezalel and Oholiab, who are filled with God's Spirit to do the work. It closes with the Sabbath command and with God giving Moses the two tablets. The next chapter will show how fast things can go wrong.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The altar of incense stands before the veil, and incense is burned on it every morning and evening (30:1-10).
2. Each person aged twenty and over pays a half shekel as a ransom for his life, "that there be no plague among them" (30:11-16). The rich do not pay more and the poor do not pay less.
3. Aaron and his sons must wash their hands and feet at the bronze basin "so that they may not die" (30:17-21).
4. The anointing oil is a special recipe, and it is not to be used for ordinary purposes (30:22-33).
5. The incense is "holy," and no one may make it for himself (30:34-38).

6. Bezalel is “filled with the Spirit of God, with ability and intelligence, with knowledge and all craftsmanship” (31:1-5).
7. The Sabbath is a sign between God and Israel “throughout your generations, that you may know that I, the LORD, sanctify you” (31:13).
8. “He gave to Moses, when he had finished speaking with him on Mount Sinai, the two tablets of the testimony, tablets of stone, written with the finger of God” (31:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Several themes run through these chapters. The first is atonement. The half-shekel ransom is the first time the word appears in the context of money. Everyone pays the same, because every life is equally in need of covering. No one can say that he is better than his neighbor, and no one can say that he is too poor to be included. The ransom is a quiet equalizer.

The second is the pattern of washing before service. The priests have to wash their hands and feet “so that they may not die.” The language is stark. God’s holiness is not something to take lightly. The bronze basin is placed between the altar and the tent, so a priest passes it on the way in. The point is cleanliness. A sinner does not approach a holy God casually.

The third is the Spirit-filled craftsman. It is a remarkable detail. Bezalel is the first person in the Bible described as filled with the Spirit of God, and the gift is for craftsmanship: woodworking, metalwork, and cutting stones. The Spirit is not only for prophets and priests. He equips people for skilled work in the service of God. If you have a skill, whether in teaching, building, cooking, or counting, it is a gift from the Spirit of God.

The fourth is the Sabbath. After all the instructions for building a sanctuary, God ends with the Sabbath. It is a deliberate order. The people are about to build a holy place, and God reminds them that holiness is also a matter of time. The Sabbath is a sign of the covenant, a reminder that Israel does not hold itself together by work. God is the one who sanctifies them. Even the project of building the tabernacle has to stop on the seventh day.

The final verse looks ahead. God writes on the tablets with his own finger. Moses will come down in the next chapter to a camp that has already broken the covenant.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that believers are not our own: we were “bought with a price” (1 Corinthians 6:20). Peter says it was “not with perishable things such as silver or gold” but with the precious blood of Christ (1 Peter 1:18-19). The Spirit who filled Bezalel fills every believer (Acts 2:4;

Ephesians 1:13), and Paul lists the gifts he gives for the common good (1 Corinthians 12:4-11). Hebrews 4:9-10 says that a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that the price of your redemption is the same for everyone, and that you cannot buy your way into his favor.

Think of the abilities God has given you. Ask the Spirit to help you use one of them this week in service to his people.

Treat the Sabbath as a gift. Ask yourself whether you are truly resting on the one day in seven set apart for it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that you are not your own.
- Ask him to fill you with his Spirit and use your skills for his glory.
- Ask him to teach you to rest in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 122 · WEEK 18

Exodus 32:1-33:23

The golden calf; Moses intercedes; God's glory and grace

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 32:1-33:23. This is one of the most dramatic passages in the Bible. The people break the covenant within weeks of making it, and Moses pleads for them on the mountain. Read it slowly and notice who speaks, who changes, and who is revealed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses has been on the mountain for forty days, and the people below have grown restless. They believe he will not come back. While God is giving instructions for a house where he will live, Israel is building an idol at the foot of the mountain. The golden calf is the most serious sin of Israel in the wilderness, and its effects run through the rest of the Old Testament. It is also the occasion for one of the most powerful scenes of intercession in all of Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people say, "Up, make us gods who shall go before us. As for this Moses, the man who brought us up out of the land of Egypt, we do not know what has become of him" (32:1).
2. Aaron collects gold, forms a calf, and declares a feast to the LORD (32:2-6). They say, "These are your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt" (32:4).
3. God tells Moses, "Your people, whom you brought up out of the land of Egypt, have corrupted themselves" (32:7).
4. Moses pleads with God, appealing to his reputation and to his promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Israel (32:11-13). "And the LORD relented from the disaster that he had spoken of bringing on his people" (32:14).

5. Moses breaks the tablets, grinds up the calf, and makes the people drink it (32:19-20).
6. The Levites rally to Moses, and about three thousand die (32:26-28).
7. Moses says, “Now, if you will forgive their sin, but if not, please blot me out of your book that you have written” (32:32).
8. God promises, “My presence will go with you, and I will give you rest” (33:14). Moses asks, “Please show me your glory” (33:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The golden calf is a lesson in how quickly people fall. Israel has just heard God speak, and they have promised, “All that the LORD has spoken we will do” (24:7). Within weeks, they are worshiping an idol. The sin is not that they stopped worshiping the LORD. They called the calf their deliverer from Egypt and held a feast “to the LORD.” Their sin was to make God into what they wanted him to be, a visible and manageable image. The second commandment was broken before the ink was dry.

Notice what God says to Moses. “Your people, whom you brought up.” God speaks as if Israel were no longer his. Moses answers by saying, “Your people, whom you have brought out.” It is a quiet but important exchange. Moses will not let go of the relationship. He argues from God’s own words and God’s own name. It is a model of prayer: Moses holds God to his promises, and God relents.

Moses’ offer in 32:32 is stunning. He asks to be blotted out of God’s book if the people cannot be forgiven. He is willing to bear their punishment. God does not accept the offer. No ordinary man can pay for another man’s sin. But the offer points ahead to someone who can.

Chapter 33 is the heart of the passage. God says that he will send an angel but will not go with them, because they are a “stiff-necked people.” Moses will not move without the presence of God. “If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here” (33:15). The whole point of the exodus was to bring God’s presence among them. Without it, the land would mean nothing. God agrees. Then Moses asks for the most daring thing: “Please show me your glory.” God answers by showing his goodness and proclaiming his name, and he covers Moses in the cleft of the rock, so that Moses sees only God’s back. No sinner can see God’s face and live.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ has done what Moses offered but could not do: he became a curse for us (Galatians 3:13), and he was "made sin" on our behalf (2 Corinthians 5:21). Paul also wished himself accursed for his people (Romans 9:3), echoing Moses. Jesus, the "one mediator between God and men" (1 Timothy 2:5), intercedes for us (Hebrews 7:25). John says that no one has ever seen God, but the Son "has made him known" (John 1:18). Paul says that we see the glory of God "in the face of Jesus Christ" (2 Corinthians 4:6).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what idol you are tempted to build when God seems to be slow. Name it honestly in prayer.

Learn from Moses' example. Use God's own promises when you pray. Find one promise in this week's reading and pray it back to him.

Echo Moses' words: "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here." Ask God to make his presence the thing you want most.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the idols you make when you are impatient.
- Thank Jesus for doing what Moses could not.
- Ask him to go with you, and to make his presence more precious than anything else.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 123 · WEEK 18

Exodus 34:1-35:35

Covenant renewed; the law rewritten; Moses' face shines

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 34:1-35:35. After the golden calf, the covenant is renewed. This is the other side of the story, and one of the most important statements of God's character in the Old Testament. Read the proclamation of his name in 34:6-7 slowly, and notice how often the rest of the Bible returns to it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses has interceded, and God has agreed to go with Israel. Now Moses is called back up the mountain with two new stone tablets. This time God does not simply give the commands. He proclaims his own name and character first. Then he renews the covenant, and Moses comes down with a face that shines. Chapter 35 begins the account of building the tabernacle, after the long set of instructions. The people respond with overflowing generosity.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Moses to cut two tablets "like the first," and he will write on them himself (34:1).
2. "The LORD passed before him and proclaimed, The LORD, the LORD, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness" (34:6).
3. God continues: "keeping steadfast love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, but who will by no means clear the guilty" (34:7).
4. Moses bows and worships at once, and asks God to go with them and pardon their iniquity (34:8-9).
5. God warns against making covenants with the people of the land and against idolatry (34:11-17).

6. Moses stays on the mountain forty days and nights, and writes "the words of the covenant, the Ten Commandments" (34:28).

7. Moses' face shines so brightly that the people are afraid, and he puts a veil over it when he is not speaking with God (34:29-35).

8. In chapter 35, the people bring gifts "every one whose heart stirred him, and everyone whose spirit moved him" (35:21), and the response is so great that Moses has to tell them to stop (36:5-7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Exodus 34:6-7 is the center of the passage and one of the most quoted verses in the Old Testament. It is the answer to Moses' prayer, "Show me your glory." God's glory, it turns out, is his character: mercy, grace, patience, love, and faithfulness. The list begins with mercy and ends with justice, and every word is deliberate. God forgives sin, and he does not ignore it.

The proclamation is repeated throughout the Bible. David uses it in Psalm 86:15 and 103:8. Joel quotes it in Joel 2:13, and Jonah complains about it: "I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful" (Jonah 4:2). It is a creed that Israel returned to again and again. When they sinned, they remembered who God is.

Look at what comes right after the proclamation. Moses bows down and prays. He does not argue. He worships and asks for pardon. The same man who was bold on behalf of the people is now humble in the presence of God's glory. The two postures belong together.

The renewed covenant shows grace at work. God could have ended things at the calf. Instead he cuts new tablets, with Moses doing the carving and God doing the writing. The broken covenant is mended, not because Israel has earned it, but because God is merciful.

The shining face is a sign that anyone who spends time in God's presence is changed. Moses does not know his face is shining (34:29). He has been with God, and it shows. The veil is for the sake of the people, who cannot bear to look. Paul will make much of this in 2 Corinthians 3.

Finally, the people's generosity in chapters 35 and 36 is the fitting response. They give so much that Moses has to tell them to stop. Forgiven people give freely.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul compares Moses' veiled face with the unveiled glory of Christ. "And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another" (2 Corinthians 3:18). John writes that the Word was "full of grace and truth" (John 1:14), using the words of Exodus 34:6. Jesus is the full revelation of God's glory (Hebrews 1:3), and the Father's steadfast love is shown in him.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Exodus 34:6-7, or at least the first half. Return to it when you doubt God's goodness.

Ask what it would mean for you to spend time with God so that others notice a change in you.

If God has forgiven you something, ask how you can respond with generosity this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in love.
- Thank him for forgiving you in Christ.
- Ask him to change you by your time with him and to make you generous.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 124 · WEEK 18

Psalm 15

Who may dwell on your holy hill?

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 15. It is short, with only five verses, and it asks a question that the tabernacle readings have raised again and again. Read it as a response to the instructions for the tent: who is fit to enter?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 15 is attributed to David. It begins with a question that fits the setting of worship at the sanctuary: "O LORD, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill?" The "tent" and "holy hill" are the tabernacle and Jerusalem. After a week spent in the instructions for the tabernacle, this psalm answers from the point of view of a worshiper. It may have been used as an entrance liturgy, a set of questions asked at the gate by the priests.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The question: "O LORD, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill?" (v. 1).
2. The answer begins: "He who walks blamelessly and does what is right and speaks truth in his heart" (v. 2).
3. The person "does not slander with his tongue and does no evil to his neighbor, nor takes up a reproach against his friend" (v. 3).
4. He despises "a vile person" and honors "those who fear the LORD" (v. 4).
5. He "swears to his own hurt and does not change" (v. 4).
6. He does not put out his money at interest or take a bribe against the innocent (v. 5).
7. The psalm ends with a promise: "He who does these things shall never be moved" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm asks the question every worshiper of the tabernacle had to ask: who is allowed in? The answer is not about ritual. It is about character, and most of it is about how a person treats other people. Truthfulness, honesty in speech, faithfulness to promises, and fairness in money are the marks of someone who belongs in God's presence. The list is surprisingly practical. It is a picture of integrity in daily life.

Notice that the list begins and ends with a general statement: someone who "walks blamelessly" will "never be moved." The portrait is of a person whose inner life and outer life match. "Speaks truth in his heart" means that his words are the same as his thoughts. He does not say one thing and mean another.

It is wise to read this psalm with the laws of Leviticus in view. The sacrifices did not replace the call to live rightly. God never wanted offerings from people who ignored their neighbors. The prophets will say the same thing later. A sacrifice offered by someone who lies, slanders, and cheats is an insult.

But we must be honest. If we read this psalm as a checklist, we all fail. None of us walks blamelessly. Taken seriously, the psalm brings us to the same place as the tabernacle: we need someone to qualify us. The question is still open, and the next psalm will make it sharper.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the only one who truly walked blamelessly, and who spoke truth in his heart. He is the one who can dwell on God's holy hill, and he brings his people with him. Isaiah 33:14-16 asks a similar question and gives a similar answer. Paul says that we have been made "holy and blameless before him" in Christ (Ephesians 1:4). Hebrews 12:22 says that we have come to "Mount Zion and to the city of the living God."

STEP 6

Application

Read the list in verses 2 to 5 slowly. Pick one item where you feel convicted, and confess it.

Ask whether your speech is honest. Is there something you have said recently that was not quite true?

Thank God that in Christ you are welcome in his tent, not because you pass the list, but because Jesus did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask yourself honestly who may dwell on God's holy hill, and tell him what you find.

Thank Jesus for walking blamelessly and bringing you in.

Ask him to make you truthful, faithful, and fair.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 125 · WEEK 18

Psalm 24

Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD?

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 24. Yesterday's psalm asked who may stand in God's presence. Today's asks the same question again, and then celebrates the arrival of the King. Read the last section, verses 7 to 10, aloud as a procession.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 24 is a psalm of David and was probably sung when the ark was brought up to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6). It has three parts: the earth belongs to the LORD (vv. 1-2), only the pure may come into his presence (vv. 3-6), and the gates must open for the King of glory (vv. 7-10). It joins together the tabernacle themes you have been reading about this week: God's holiness, the need for clean hands, and the ark of his presence.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell in it" (v. 1).
2. He "has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers" (v. 2).
3. "Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place?" (v. 3).
4. "He who has clean hands and a pure heart, who does not lift up his soul to what is false and does not swear deceitfully" (v. 4).
5. "He will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation" (v. 5).
6. "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in" (v. 7).

7. “Who is this King of glory? The LORD, strong and mighty, the LORD, mighty in battle!” (v. 8).

8. The question is asked again, and the answer changes: “The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory!” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a broad claim: everything belongs to God. He founded the earth. It is not a neutral world that we are free to use as we like. The earth is his. That is the basis for all that follows. The God who owns the world has the right to say who may come to his house.

Then comes the question of verse 3, the same as Psalm 15. The answer is about hands and heart: outward and inward cleanness. Notice that the one who ascends “will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation.” Righteousness here is something received. It is not only earned. The one who is fit to stand in God’s presence has been given a righteousness he did not make.

The last section is a drama. The procession arrives at the gates of Jerusalem with the ark, and the gates are told to open. A voice from inside asks, “Who is this King of glory?” The answer comes: the LORD, strong and mighty in battle. The same exchange is repeated, and the title grows: “the LORD of hosts.” The ark is the sign of God’s presence, and the God who comes is a conquering King.

Look at how the psalm moves. It begins with the earth belonging to God, then asks who can come near to him, and ends with the King coming to us. The answer to the problem of who may ascend the hill is that the King descends. He comes to the gates, and he asks to be let in. It is a picture of the God who draws near to his people.

STEP 5

Connection

The early church read this psalm as a picture of Christ’s ascension. He is the one with clean hands and a pure heart, who ascended the holy hill and now sits at the right hand of the Father (Ephesians 4:8-10; Hebrews 4:14). Paul says that “the earth is the Lord’s, and everything in it” (1 Corinthians 10:26). Revelation 19:11-16 shows the King of glory returning as a conqueror. Jesus also stands at the door of the church and knocks (Revelation 3:20).

STEP 6

Application

Think of one thing in your life you tend to treat as belonging to you: money, time, or plans. Say aloud, “This is the LORD’s.”

Pray verse 7 as an invitation. Ask the King of glory to come in to a part of your life you have kept closed.

Thank Jesus that he ascended on your behalf, and that you can follow him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Welcome the King of glory into the rooms of your life that you tend to keep closed.
- Thank Jesus for ascending with clean hands and a pure heart.
- Praise him as the owner of everything.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 126 · WEEK 18

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 24:3-4 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

REST

Meditation

Psalm 24:3-4 asks a question that the whole week has been asking, and gives an answer that should humble and then comfort you.

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD?" The hill is Zion, the place of the sanctuary. To ascend is to approach God. It is the question of every religion: how can a person get close to the divine? The Bible's answer is honest. It is not for everyone.

"He who has clean hands and a pure heart." The answer has two parts, hands and heart. The hands stand for what we do, and the heart for what we are. God wants both. It is not enough to look clean. It is not enough to mean well. Both must be clean.

If you are honest, the verse is a problem. No one has clean hands and a pure heart. This is the very reason the tabernacle was built, with its altar, its priests, and its blood. A sinner cannot ascend on his own.

Then comes the gospel. Jesus is the one with clean hands and a pure heart. He ascended the hill. He did not do it for himself. He did it as your representative, and in him you are given "blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation" (Psalm 24:5). Because of Christ, you can draw near with confidence (Hebrews 10:19-22).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the instructions for the tabernacle and watched Israel break the covenant almost at once. You read about the altar and the priests' garments, the ordination of Aaron and his sons, and the extra items God commanded: the altar of incense, the basin, the oil, and the Spirit-filled craftsmen. You saw the golden calf, Moses' intercession, and his request to see God's glory. You heard God proclaim his name in Exodus 34:6-7 and saw the covenant renewed. You prayed through two psalms that ask who may enter God's presence, Psalm 15 and Psalm 24. The week taught that God desires to dwell with his people, that sinners need a mediator, and that his glory is his mercy.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God described himself as "merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness." Which of these words do you most need to hear today, and why?

Moses offered to be blotted out for the sake of the people, but God did not accept it. How does Jesus fulfill what Moses could only wish? What does that mean for how you pray?

Psalms 15 and 24 describe someone fit to enter God's presence. Where do you fall short of the picture, and how does it change your heart to know that Christ has qualified you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are not left outside his tent.

Thank Jesus for bringing you in.

Rest in him today.

DAY 127 · WEEK 19

Exodus 36:1-38:31

The Tabernacle is built, every detail according to the pattern

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 36:1-38:31. After the long instructions, you now watch the work being done. Much of the text repeats what you read in chapters 25 to 31. As you read, notice what the repetition is meant to show.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The instructions are complete and the golden calf has been dealt with. Now the people build the tabernacle. Bezalel, Oholiab, and the skilled workers receive the offerings and do the work. The text slows down and tells again, almost word for word, what was commanded earlier, this time in the past tense. The point is not to tell you something new. It is to show you that the work was done exactly as God said.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people bring so much that Moses has to restrain them: “The people bring much more than enough for doing the work” (36:5-6).
2. The craftsmen make the curtains, the frames, and the veil, using the same materials and dimensions as in chapters 25 and 26 (36:8-38).
3. Bezalel makes the ark, the table, the lampstand, the altar of incense, and the oil and incense (37:1-29).
4. The bronze basin is made from “the mirrors of the ministering women who ministered in the entrance of the tent of meeting” (38:8).
5. The bronze altar, the courtyard, and its pillars are made (38:1-20).
6. The total of the gold, silver, and bronze is carefully recorded (38:21-31).

7. The silver from the census, a half shekel per person, is used to make the bases for the frames and veil (38:25-28).

8. Bezalel does “all that the LORD commanded Moses” (38:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

It is easy to skim a chapter that repeats itself. Do not. The repetition is the message. When Exodus 36 to 38 says that the craftsmen made it “as the LORD had commanded Moses,” it is saying that Israel, who failed so badly at the golden calf, now obeys. The pattern of rebellion, intercession, forgiveness, and renewed obedience is one of the most important in the book.

The second thing to note is the generosity. The people bring so much that Moses has to stop them. This is the opposite of the golden calf. At the calf, they gave their gold to make an idol. Now they give their gold, silver, and bronze for the worship of the true God. The same people, the same metals, a different heart.

The third thing is the humble detail of the bronze basin. It is made from the mirrors of the women who served at the entrance of the tent. Someone gave up a prized personal possession so that the priests could be washed. It is not a large gift, and yet it is recorded forever. God notices what we give, and he does not forget.

The fourth is the use of the census silver. The ransom money, paid equally by each person, forms the foundation of the sanctuary. The bases that hold the whole tent up are made of redemption money. It is a quiet picture of the way God’s dwelling place stands on atonement. The whole structure rests on the fact that each person has been ransomed.

Finally, the long accounts of metal remind you that the tabernacle was real, tangible, and costly. It was not a spiritual idea. It was built with real labor and real gifts, by people who gave their time and skill.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul calls the church God’s building and says that “Jesus Christ himself being the cornerstone” holds it together (Ephesians 2:20-22). Peter says we are “living stones” being built into a spiritual house (1 Peter 2:5). The foundation is the ransom paid by Christ, “a lamb without blemish or spot” (1 Peter 1:19). Paul praises generous giving as “a fragrant offering” (Philippians 4:18).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the difference between the golden calf and the tabernacle. Ask whether anything you give, in time, money, or talent, is going toward something that cannot give life.

Give something this week, anonymously if you can, and without being asked.

Thank God that the foundation of your life with him is a ransom already paid.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the people who give cheerfully, and ask him to make you one.

Thank him for the ransom that is the foundation of his house.

Ask him to make you a living stone in what he is building.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 128 · WEEK 19

Exodus 39:1-40:38

Priestly garments made; the glory fills the Tabernacle

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 39:1-40:38. This reading ends the book of Exodus. The garments are completed, the tabernacle is set up, and the glory of God comes down. Read the last paragraph with particular attention, because it is the goal of the whole book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The priestly clothing is finished, and Moses inspects the work. A year after leaving Egypt, on the first day of the first month, the tabernacle is set up (40:17). Each piece is put in its place, and then something happens that no one could have arranged: God's glory fills the tent. This is the climax of Exodus. The book that began with Israel in slavery ends with God living among his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The priestly garments, ephod, breastpiece, robe, and turban, are made "as the LORD had commanded Moses" (39:1, 5, 7, 21, 26, 29, 31).
2. The plate of the holy crown is engraved "Holy to the LORD" (39:30-31).
3. Moses inspects the work: "Behold, they had done it; as the LORD had commanded, so had they done it. Then Moses blessed them" (39:43).
4. The tabernacle is erected on the first day of the first month, in the second year (40:2, 17).
5. Moses puts the testimony in the ark, sets the mercy seat on top, and brings the ark into the tent (40:20-21).

6. He anoints the tabernacle and the furniture, and washes and clothes Aaron and his sons (40:9-15, 30-32).
7. "So Moses finished the work" (40:33).
8. "Then the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle. And Moses was not able to enter the tent of meeting because the cloud settled on it, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle" (40:34-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The last chapter of Exodus echoes the first chapter of Genesis. In Genesis, God makes the world in six days and sees that it is good, and then he blesses it. In Exodus, Moses finishes the tabernacle, looks at the work, and blesses it. The words "So Moses finished the work" (40:33) are almost the same as "Thus the heavens and the earth were finished" (Genesis 2:1). The tabernacle is a new creation, a small world in which God and people may meet.

The date is also significant. The tabernacle is erected on the first day of the first month. It is a new beginning. Israel left Egypt in the month of Passover, and now a year later they have a new center to their life: a sanctuary for the God who brought them out.

Then the glory comes. The same cloud that led them through the wilderness settles on the tent, and God's presence fills the space so completely that even Moses cannot go in. It is a double lesson. God has come near. And he is still holy. Moses, the friend of God who spoke to him face to face, cannot enter. The nearness of God does not remove his majesty.

The book closes with a description of how the cloud guided Israel. When it lifted, they moved. When it rested, they camped (40:36-38). Their journey was ruled by the presence of God. They did not decide where to go. They followed him. This is the answer to Moses' prayer in chapter 33, "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here." It will go with them, day and night, "in the sight of all the house of Israel throughout all their journeys."

Exodus began with a groaning people and a hidden God, and it ends with a people who have seen his glory. The book is a short version of the whole Bible: redemption leads to God's presence. But the story is not finished, because Moses cannot enter. Leviticus will explain how others can.

STEP 5

Connection

John says that Jesus “dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory” (John 1:14). At the dedication of Solomon’s temple, the glory fills the house in the same way (1 Kings 8:10-11). Paul says that believers are God’s temple (1 Corinthians 3:16), and Revelation shows the glory of God filling the new Jerusalem so that it has no need of the sun (Revelation 21:23).

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the end of Exodus. God rescued his people so that he could live with them. Thank him that this is the goal of your salvation, and not only forgiveness.

Ask yourself how much of your life is guided by his presence, and how much by your own plans.

Spend a few quiet minutes asking God to fill your life with his glory.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that his glory fills his church.
- Ask him to lead you day by day.
- Ask him to let his presence rule your journey.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

“Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified.”

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 129 · WEEK 19

Leviticus 1:1-3:17

Burnt, grain, and peace offerings, substitution and fellowship

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 1:1-3:17. A new book begins, and it starts with sacrifice. These chapters can feel strange and bloody, so read them as a guide to the way God teaches. Each offering has its own meaning, and you can learn to see it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Leviticus picks up exactly where Exodus ends. God speaks to Moses "from the tent of meeting," since Moses could not enter it in Exodus 40. The book is mostly a manual for priests and people on how to live near a holy God. It is the central book of the Pentateuch, and its theme is holiness. It begins with the sacrifices, because without a way to deal with sin, no one could survive in God's presence. Today's reading covers three of the five main offerings: the burnt offering, the grain offering, and the peace offering.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The burnt offering is a male without blemish. The worshiper lays his hand on its head, "and it shall be accepted for him to make atonement for him" (1:3-4).
2. The whole animal is burned on the altar, "a pleasing aroma to the LORD" (1:9).
3. The offering can be a bull, a sheep or goat, or a bird, depending on what the worshiper can afford (1:3, 10, 14).
4. The grain offering is of fine flour with oil and frankincense, and it is to be seasoned with salt but not leaven or honey (2:1-13).
5. Part of the grain offering is burned as a "memorial portion," and the rest is for the priests (2:2-3).

6. The peace offering is shared. Part is burned, part goes to the priest, and the worshiper eats the rest (3:1-17; see 7:11-18).

7. Throughout, the fat and the blood belong to the LORD: "It is a statute forever throughout your generations, in all your dwelling places, that you eat neither fat nor blood" (3:17).

8. The phrase "a pleasing aroma to the LORD" appears repeatedly (1:9, 13, 17; 2:2, 9; 3:5, 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three offerings you read today teach three different things about the relationship between God and his people.

The burnt offering is about atonement and total dedication. The whole animal goes up in smoke. The worshiper lays his hand on its head, and the animal dies in his place. The word "atonement" means a covering or a ransom. The sinner has forfeited his life, and the animal's life is accepted instead. Because the whole animal is burned, it also pictures total surrender to God, a life given entirely to him.

The grain offering is a gift of thanks. It does not involve blood. It is an offering of the fruit of the worshiper's work, flour and oil, given back to the God who provided it. It is a reminder that atonement is not the only thing in the worship of Israel. There is also gratitude.

The peace offering is the happiest of the three, and it is about fellowship. The worshiper eats part of the sacrifice, in the presence of God, with the priest and often with family and friends. After atonement and thanks, here is a meal. It is a picture of what the whole system is for: peace between God and people, shared at a table.

Notice three details that run through the chapters. First, the offering is costly. Whatever you bring must be without blemish. Second, it is accessible. A poor person could bring a bird, a handful of flour, or a dove. No one was shut out for lack of means. Third, the blood and fat belong to God, because "the life of the flesh is in the blood" (17:11), a verse you will read soon and the anchor of this unit.

The repeated phrase "a pleasing aroma" is not about smell. It means that God accepts the offering. The sacrifice is not a bribe to a hungry god. It is a way for sinners to come to a holy God and be received.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ "gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God" (Ephesians 5:2). He is the burnt offering, giving himself entirely. He is also our peace offering: he "is our peace" (Ephesians 2:14), and in the Lord's Supper we eat at his table. Paul says that Christians offer their bodies "as a living sacrifice" (Romans 12:1). Hebrews 13:15-16 speaks of a "sacrifice of praise" and sharing what we have.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes thanking God for the gift of Christ, the one who was the perfect, complete, and accepted offering.

Ask whether you have held anything back from God. Name it and offer it to him.

The next time you take part in the Lord's Supper, remember that it is a fellowship meal at the table of the one who made peace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the perfect sacrifice in Jesus.
- Give thanks for the atonement, the gratitude, and the peace it brings.
- Offer him your life in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 130 · WEEK 19

Leviticus 4:1-5:19

Sin and guilt offerings, the cost of atonement

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 4:1-5:19. Yesterday's offerings were voluntary gifts of worship. Today's are required, because they deal with sin. Notice who sins, how, and what each offering costs.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first three offerings in Leviticus were "sweet-smelling" ones, freely given in worship. Chapters 4 and 5 describe two offerings that are required when someone has sinned: the sin offering, or purification offering, and the guilt offering, or reparation offering. These deal with unintentional sin, wrongs done without the person realizing it at the time. They show that sin has consequences even when it is not deliberate, and they show that God provides a way for it to be cleansed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The sin offering applies to anyone who sins "unintentionally" (4:2, 13, 22, 27).
2. The offering differs by rank: a bull for the anointed priest and for the whole congregation, a male goat for a leader, and a female goat or lamb for a common person (4:3, 14, 22-23, 27-28).
3. For the priest and congregation, blood is sprinkled before the veil and put on the horns of the altar of incense (4:6-7, 17-18).
4. The person lays a hand on the head of the animal and kills it (4:4, 24, 29).
5. "And the priest shall make atonement for him, and he shall be forgiven" (4:20, 26, 31, 35).

6. The remains of the bull for the priest or congregation are burned outside the camp (4:11-12, 21).
7. For those who cannot afford an animal, there are provisions for birds and even fine flour (5:7-13).
8. The guilt offering requires restitution plus a fifth of the value, along with a ram (5:14-6:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to notice is how seriously Leviticus takes sin. Even unintentional sin requires a sacrifice. This is surprising to modern readers. We often think that sin matters only when it is deliberate. Leviticus says that sin has an objective weight, and that it defiles. This is part of what it means that God is holy: he is so pure that even accidental contact with sin makes a person unclean. The text is teaching us that sin is not just about our intentions.

The second thing is the scale of the offerings. The cost rises with the person's position. A priest who sins brings a bull, just as the whole community does. Why? Because the sin of a leader affects everyone. The more influence a person has, the heavier the consequences of his sin. A common person brings a goat or lamb, and a poor person a bird. God's grace is flexible, but his standard of holiness is not.

The third is the blood on the altar of incense and before the veil. The blood goes closer to God's presence when the sin involves the priest or the whole people. It shows that sin does more than offend an individual. It pollutes the sanctuary itself. That is why the Day of Atonement, which you will read in a few days, includes cleansing the tabernacle.

The fourth is the repeated refrain: "and he shall be forgiven." It is the goal of the chapters. Sacrifice is not just a way of paying a price. It is a way of being forgiven. The sinner lays his hand on the animal's head, the animal dies in his place, the priest applies the blood, and the person is cleansed. The worshiper leaves forgiven.

The guilt offering adds a lesson. Sin against a neighbor requires more than a sacrifice. It requires restitution, repaying what was taken, with a fifth added. Forgiveness from God does not cancel the duty to make things right with people.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 13:11-12 says that the bodies of the animals for the sin offering were burned outside the camp, "so Jesus also suffered outside the gate in order to sanctify the people through his own blood." Paul says that God "made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we

might become the righteousness of God" (2 Corinthians 5:21). The word for "sin offering" in the Greek Old Testament is the same as the word for "sin" there. Isaiah 53:10 says the servant's life is made "an offering for guilt." Zacchaeus' restitution (Luke 19:8) shows the same principle.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on whether you take unintentional sin seriously. Ask God to show you something you have not noticed.

Think of a wrong you have done to someone. Is there something you could do to make it right?

Thank God that the sin offering is finished in Christ, and that you can say "and he shall be forgiven" about yourself.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to forgive the sins you do not see.
- Thank Jesus for being sacrificed outside the gate for you.
- Ask him to show you what you need to make right.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 131 · WEEK 19

Leviticus 6:1-7:38

Priestly instructions for the offerings

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 6:1-7:38. These chapters repeat the offerings and add instructions for the priests. They can feel technical, so look for what they tell you about the priests' role and about the way worshipers were fed and cared for.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 1 to 5 were addressed mainly to the people, telling them what to bring. Chapters 6 and 7 are addressed to Aaron and his sons, telling the priests what to do with the offerings. They go over the burnt offering, the grain offering, the sin offering, the guilt offering, and the peace offering again, this time from the priest's perspective. They show what happens to the meat, who may eat it, and how to guard its holiness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The fire on the altar "shall not go out" (6:9, 12-13).
2. The priest wears linen garments to remove the ashes, and then changes clothes to carry them outside the camp (6:10-11).
3. The grain offering is eaten by the priests, "in a holy place" (6:16-18).
4. Anything that touches the sin offering becomes holy (6:27).
5. The guilt offering is "most holy," and the priest who offers it may eat it (7:1-7).
6. The priests receive a share of the offerings for their support (7:6-10, 31-36).
7. The peace offering must be eaten within one or two days, and anyone who eats it while unclean "shall be cut off from his people" (7:15-21).
8. The fat and blood are forbidden to eat (7:22-27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The detailed instructions reveal several truths. The first is the unbroken fire. The burnt offering fire on the altar must never go out. It was lit by God himself (Leviticus 9:24), and it was to be kept burning day and night. The priest's job each morning was to add wood and keep it alive. It is a picture of constant readiness. The way to God is always open, and the place of sacrifice never goes cold.

The second is the care for holiness. The priests change clothes. The ashes are carried to a clean place outside the camp. The utensils that touch the sin offering have to be cleaned or destroyed. The details teach that holy things are not to be treated casually. God's holiness is not passive. It sanctifies what touches it, and it is dangerous to what is unclean.

The third is the provision for the priests. They receive a share of the offerings as their food. God does not ask them to serve without support. This is an early example of the principle that "those who proclaim the gospel should get their living by the gospel" (1 Corinthians 9:14). It is also a reminder that the people's offerings feed those who serve them in worship.

The fourth is the careful rules for the peace offering. It must be eaten promptly and in a state of cleanness. A feast with God is not to be taken lightly. To come to the table when unclean is to risk being "cut off." This will be echoed in the New Testament, where Paul warns about taking the Lord's Supper "in an unworthy manner" (1 Corinthians 11:27).

Finally, the prohibition on eating blood is repeated, because blood is the life and belongs to God. This is the reason that blood is used for atonement. You will read the explanation in Leviticus 17:11.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the priest who offered himself, and he is also the sacrifice that feeds his people. "Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life" (John 6:54). The fire that never goes out points to the Spirit who has been given to us (Acts 2:3). Paul says that Christians should "present your bodies as a living sacrifice" (Romans 12:1), and Peter says that we are priests who offer "spiritual sacrifices" (1 Peter 2:5).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether the fire of worship is still burning in your life, or whether it has gone cold.

Think about how you support those who serve you spiritually, such as a pastor, a teacher, or a missionary. Is there a way you could support them more?

Next time you take communion, prepare yourself with care, and approach the table with reverence and gratitude.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep the fire of love for him burning in you.
- Thank him for feeding his people with himself.
- Ask him to teach you to approach his table with reverence.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 132 · WEEK 19

Leviticus 8:1-10:20

Priestly ordination; Nadab and Abihu, God's holiness is not safe

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 8:1-10:20. This reading includes the ordination of the priests, the first sacrifices, and a terrible event on the first day. Read the contrast between chapter 9 and chapter 10 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The instructions in Leviticus 1 to 7 were given at Sinai. Now the narrative moves forward. In chapter 8, Moses carries out the ordination ceremony that was described in Exodus 29. In chapter 9, on the eighth day, the priests begin their ministry. In chapter 10, two of Aaron's sons make an offering that God did not command, and they die. The sequence shows both the glory of God's provision and the danger of approaching him on our own terms.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses washes Aaron and his sons, dresses them, anoints them, and offers the sin offering, the burnt offering, and the ordination offering (8:1-30).
2. The priests must stay at the entrance of the tent for seven days, "so that you may not die" (8:33-35).
3. On the eighth day, Aaron offers the sacrifices for himself and for the people (9:1-21).
4. Aaron blesses the people, and "the glory of the LORD appeared to all the people" (9:22-23).
5. "Fire came out from before the LORD and consumed the burnt offering and the fat on the altar, and when all the people saw it, they shouted and fell on their faces" (9:24).

6. Nadab and Abihu "offered unauthorized fire before the LORD, which he had not commanded them" (10:1).
7. "Fire came out from before the LORD and consumed them, and they died before the LORD" (10:2).
8. Moses says, "This is what the LORD has said: Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified" (10:3). "And Aaron held his peace."

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is one of the hardest passages in the Old Testament, so take it slowly. It shows two sides of God. In chapter 9, the glory of God appears and fire from heaven accepts the sacrifice. The people shout and fall on their faces. It is an overwhelming scene of acceptance. God has provided a way, the priests have done what he commanded, and he has come down to be with them.

In chapter 10, the same fire that consumed the sacrifice consumes two priests. The difference is that Nadab and Abihu offered "unauthorized fire." The text does not say exactly what was wrong with it. It says only that it was something God "had not commanded." The lesson is more important than the details. God is not to be approached in just any way we choose. He has told us how to worship, and worship that goes beyond his word is dangerous.

The event happens on the very day the priesthood begins. It is a warning at the start. The text is saying that God's holiness is not a matter of mood or ritual. It is who he is, and those who serve near him must take it seriously. Moses' explanation is the key: "Among those who are near me I will be sanctified." Those who are closest to God are held to the highest standard.

Aaron's silence in the face of the loss of his sons is a moment of great restraint. He does not argue, and he does not accuse God. He holds his peace. It is a hard, quiet response to a hard event.

We must also remember that the story is not meant to tell us that God is arbitrary. The sacrifices were provided for exactly this reason: so that sinners could approach safely. The danger was not in the system but in ignoring it. Those who came in the way God had commanded were welcome. Those who came another way were not.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:28-29 says, “Let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe, for our God is a consuming fire.” Peter quotes the same theme, “Be holy, for I am holy” (1 Peter 1:16). The story of Ananias and Sapphira (Acts 5:1-11) echoes it, as the early church learned a similar lesson about deceit in worship. Jesus has made a new and living way open to us (Hebrews 10:19-20), and he is the way (John 14:6).

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself whether you come to God in the way he has taught, through Christ and in his Word, or in a way that suits you.

Take a few minutes to think about the seriousness of worship. Come to church this week with reverence.

If you are grieving a loss, ask God to give you the quiet courage that Aaron showed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you think of when you hear that he is a consuming fire.
- Thank him for the new and living way in Jesus.
- Ask him to teach you to worship with reverence and awe.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

“Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified.”

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 133 · WEEK 19

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Leviticus 10:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

REST

Meditation

Leviticus 10:3 is a sober verse to hold on a day of rest. It comes right after the deaths of Nadab and Abihu, and it is the explanation God gives for what happened. Do not rush past it.

"Among those who are near me." God speaks about his priests, and by extension all who draw near to him. Nearness is a privilege. It is also a responsibility. The closer you are to God, the more seriously he takes your obedience.

"I will be sanctified." To sanctify means to treat as holy. God will be treated as holy, either by willing worship or by his own action. It is not a request. It is a statement about how the world is. He will not be ignored.

"And before all the people I will be glorified." The worship of God is public. The conduct of those who lead worship is seen by everyone. His glory is at stake in how his people approach him.

For the Christian, the verse is a call to reverence. In Christ we are brought near, closer than Aaron ever was. We are not afraid, because the sacrifice has been made. But we are not casual either. Hebrews says, “let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith” (Hebrews 10:22), and “let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe” (Hebrews 12:28).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the end of Exodus and the beginning of Leviticus. You saw the tabernacle built exactly as God commanded and the glory of the LORD fill the tent. In Leviticus you studied the five main offerings: the burnt offering, the grain offering, the peace offering, the sin offering, and the guilt offering. You read the priests’ instructions for each, and you watched the ordination of Aaron and his sons. You saw the glory of God appear, and then you saw the death of Nadab and Abihu. The week taught that God makes a way for sinners to draw near, that he asks for obedience and reverence, and that the nearer we come, the more seriously he is to be honored.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The offerings in Leviticus 1 to 7 teach atonement, thanks, and fellowship. Which of these three do you most need to experience right now?

Jesus fulfills all of the offerings. How is he your burnt offering, your sin offering, and your peace offering? Write down one way each speaks to you.

God said, “Among those who are near me I will be sanctified.” What would it look like for you to approach God with both confidence and reverence this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you to draw near with confidence and with reverence.

Thank him for opening the way through Jesus.

Rest in him, and ask him to be honored in your life.

DAY 134 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 11:1-13:59

Clean and unclean; skin diseases, holiness as separation

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 82 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 11:1-13:59. These chapters are some of the strangest in the Bible. They describe clean and unclean animals, childbirth, and skin diseases. Read them with one question in mind: what is God teaching his people about holiness?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the ordination of the priests and the offerings, Leviticus turns to the question of what is clean and unclean. The Hebrew words are tameh and tahor. “Unclean” does not mean “sinful” or “dirty.” It means unfit for the sanctuary. The laws apply to food, to childbirth, to skin diseases, and to mildew in clothing. They govern daily life, and they remind Israel at every meal and every household event that they are a people set apart.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The land animals that may be eaten are those that chew the cud and have a split hoof (11:1-8).
2. Water creatures with fins and scales are allowed, and other sea creatures are not (11:9-12).
3. Many birds and insects are named as unclean (11:13-23).
4. “For I am the LORD who brought you up out of the land of Egypt to be your God. You shall therefore be holy, for I am holy” (11:45).
5. After childbirth, a mother is unclean for a period, and then brings a burnt offering and a sin offering (12:1-8).
6. The priest examines skin conditions and declares a person clean or unclean (13:1-46).

7. The one who is unclean must "live alone. His dwelling shall be outside the camp" (13:46).

8. The same rules apply to mildew in clothing (13:47-59).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Why does God give these laws? The Bible does not give one simple answer, but the text points to several truths.

The first is explicit: the laws teach holiness. Leviticus 11:44-45 says, "For I am the LORD your God. Consecrate yourselves, and be holy, for I am holy." The food laws are one way that Israel's daily life is shaped by the idea of separation. At every meal, an Israelite was reminded that he belonged to a God who had set his people apart from the nations. These laws marked the boundary between Israel and the world.

The second is that they teach us to distinguish. The categories of clean and unclean train the people to think about the difference between what belongs in God's presence and what does not. Many of the unclean things are associated with death, decay, or disorder. The uncleanness of skin disease and discharge points to the brokenness of a world under death. These conditions were not sins, but they were signs of a fallen creation, and so they kept a person out of the sanctuary.

Third, the exclusion of the unclean person from the camp is a sobering picture. The person with a serious skin disease had to live alone, tear his clothes, and cry, "Unclean, unclean." It is one of the loneliest images in the Bible. It shows what sin and death do: they separate us from the community and from God's presence.

But note the role of the priest. He does not cause the uncleanness. He examines and pronounces. And as chapter 14 will show, the priest is also the one who declares a cleansed person clean. The system points to a need that it cannot meet. It shows that people cannot cleanse themselves.

We should be careful about using these laws for health advice, or for ranking people. They belong to Israel's life under the old covenant, and the New Testament tells us that their purpose has been fulfilled. In Mark 7:19, Jesus declares all foods clean. In Acts 10, Peter is told, "What God has made clean, do not call common."

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus touched lepers and healed them (Mark 1:40-42), and instead of being made unclean, he made them clean. Paul says that "nothing is unclean in itself" (Romans 14:14), and that in Christ the dividing wall between Jew and Gentile has been broken down (Ephesians 2:14). Hebrews 13:12 says that Jesus suffered outside the gate, in the place of the unclean. Peter's vision in Acts 10 shows the end of the food distinction as a mark of God's people.

STEP 6

Application

Think about the call to be holy and set apart. What areas of life show that you belong to God?

Remember someone who is isolated by illness, shame, or circumstance. Ask how you could reach out to them in the way that Jesus reached out to the lepers.

Thank God that in Christ, what was unclean is made clean, and that the barrier is gone.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you holy in a way that draws people to him.
- Thank Jesus for touching the unclean and making them clean.
- Ask him to show you someone who is alone and how you might reach them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 135 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 14:1-15:33

Cleansing rituals; bodily discharges, wholeness restored

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 14:1-15:33. Yesterday ended with the isolation of the unclean person. Today you read the ritual that welcomes a healed person back into the community. As you read, notice how much happens before the person is restored.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 13 described how the priest examines someone with a skin disease. Chapter 14 describes what happens when the person is healed. The priest goes out to the person, who is outside the camp, and examines him. If he is healed, a ritual with two birds and a series of offerings brings him back. Chapter 15 describes bodily discharges and the rules for cleansing. These chapters are about restoration. Where chapters 11 to 13 describe the problem, chapters 14 and 15 describe the way back.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The priest “shall go out of the camp” to examine the healed person (14:3).
2. Two live birds are taken. One is killed over fresh water, and the other, dipped in the blood, is released into the open field (14:4-7).
3. The person washes, shaves, and bathes, and then may enter the camp, but must stay outside his tent for seven days (14:8-9).
4. On the eighth day he brings a guilt offering, a sin offering, a burnt offering, and a grain offering (14:10-20).
5. Blood and oil are put on his right ear, right thumb, and right big toe, as with the priests (14:14, 17).

6. Provision is made for the poor, who may bring birds in place of lambs (14:21-32).
7. Chapter 15 describes unclean discharges, and what a person must do to be cleansed: wash, wait, and offer a sacrifice (15:1-30).
8. The purpose is stated: “Thus you shall keep the people of Israel separate from their uncleanness, so that they may not die in their uncleanness by defiling my tabernacle that is in their midst” (15:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The ritual for cleansing is more elaborate than you might expect, and it contains a beautiful picture. The healed person is outside the camp, and the priest comes to him. The priest does not wait at the sanctuary. He goes out to the one who is unclean. It is a small detail with a large meaning.

The two birds are a picture of death and release. One bird is killed, and the other is dipped in its blood and let go. The bird flies away alive and free, covered in the blood of the one that died. This is a picture of substitution and freedom. The death of one gives life to the other.

The anointing of the healed person’s ear, thumb, and toe is the same as in the ordination of the priests (Exodus 29:20). He is restored not only to the community but to something like priestly dignity. A person who was cast out of the camp is brought into the tabernacle courts, marked with blood and oil. The healed leper is treated almost as if he were a priest.

The eight days also repeat the pattern of ordination. A person who has been cleansed is given a new beginning. And the provision for the poor shows again that the way back is open to everyone. No one is permanently excluded because he cannot afford the offering.

Chapter 15 on discharges might seem the most embarrassing material in the Bible, but notice its tone. It treats the body matter-of-factly. Uncleanness is not shameful. It is something that happens in a mortal body, and it has a procedure. The principle in verse 31 is the key. The danger is not the condition itself. It is defiling the tabernacle where God lives. These rules protect the nearness of God.

STEP 5

Connection

The Gospels record that Jesus healed lepers and then told them to go and show themselves to the priest (Luke 5:12-14; 17:14). They are fulfilling these chapters. Jesus went outside the camp to reach the unclean, just as the priest did. Hebrews 9:13-14 says, “If the blood of goats

and bulls… sanctify for the purification of the flesh, how much more will the blood of Christ… purify our conscience." Paul says that we are "washed" and "sanctified" in the name of the Lord Jesus (1 Corinthians 6:11).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the picture of the priest going out of the camp. Thank Jesus for coming to find you when you were far from God.

If you know someone who feels excluded, pray for a way to welcome them.

Recall the moment you were brought into God's family. Give thanks for the new beginning he gave you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for coming outside the camp to find you.
- Ask him to help you welcome others as he welcomed you.
- Tell him what it cost him to bring you home.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 136 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 16:1-34

The Day of Atonement, the center of the entire system

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 16:1-34. This is the most important chapter in the book. Read it slowly, and picture the high priest going through the veil with blood. Then notice the two goats and what happens to each.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Day of Atonement, Yom Kippur, is the one day of the year when the high priest enters the Most Holy Place. The chapter begins with a reminder of the death of Nadab and Abihu (16:1), because the sanctuary is dangerous. Over the year, the tabernacle has been defiled by the sins of the people, and on this one day it is cleansed, and the sins of the nation are dealt with. It is the center of the whole system, and everything else in Leviticus is built around it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Aaron may not come “at any time into the Holy Place inside the veil” or he will die (16:2).
2. He bathes, puts on holy linen garments, and offers a bull for his own sin first (16:3-4, 11).
3. He takes a censer of burning coals and incense into the Most Holy Place, “so that the cloud of the incense may cover the mercy seat” (16:12-13).
4. He sprinkles the blood of the bull and the goat on the mercy seat and before it (16:14-15).
5. “Thus he shall make atonement for the Holy Place, because of the uncleannesses of the people of Israel and because of their transgressions, all their sins” (16:16).

6. Two goats are chosen. One is the LORD's, killed as a sin offering. The other is the scapegoat (16:7-10).

7. Aaron lays both hands on the live goat, confesses "all the iniquities of the people of Israel," and sends it into the wilderness (16:21-22).

8. "For on this day shall atonement be made for you to cleanse you. You shall be clean before the LORD from all your sins" (16:30). The day is to be a Sabbath of solemn rest, and a day of fasting, for all time (16:29-31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This chapter gathers up everything you have read in Leviticus so far. There are four parts, and each has a lesson.

First, there is the high priest's preparation. He cannot simply walk into God's presence. He must bathe, change his clothes, and offer a bull for his own sin. Even the mediator needs a mediator. The priest is a sinner, and his own sin has to be covered before he can cover anyone else's. There is a built-in sense that this system is incomplete.

Second, there is the entry into the Most Holy Place. Once a year, one man goes behind the veil, with a cloud of incense to shield him, and sprinkles blood on the mercy seat. This is the place where the tablets of the law lay, the testimony against Israel's sin. The blood goes between the law and the presence of God. The place that would condemn is covered by blood. This is atonement at its most vivid.

Third, there is the cleansing of the sanctuary. The tabernacle itself is purified because of the people's sin. Sin pollutes even the place where God lives, and it must be cleansed or God's presence cannot remain. This is an important idea. Sin has real effects on the world.

Fourth, there are the two goats. One dies, and its blood is used to cover sin. The other lives, and the sins of the people are placed on its head. It is sent away into the wilderness, to a remote and uninhabited place (16:22). Together, the two goats show two sides of atonement: sin is paid for, and sin is carried away. The people see their sin removed, and they know that it is gone.

Yet the sacrifice has to be repeated every year. Hebrews will say that this repetition is itself the proof that the blood of animals cannot finally take away sin. The Day of Atonement points beyond itself to a greater sacrifice, one that does not need to be offered again.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 9 and 10 interpret this chapter in detail. Christ entered "once for all into the holy places, not by means of the blood of goats and calves but by means of his own blood, thus securing an eternal redemption" (Hebrews 9:12). The veil was torn in two at his death (Matthew 27:51). He is the sacrifice and the high priest. Romans 3:25 says that God put him forward "as a propitiation by his blood." John the Baptist says, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29), and Isaiah 53:6 says that "the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all."

STEP 6

Application

Read Hebrews 9:11-14 and 10:19-22 today. Notice the contrast with Leviticus 16, and thank God for the finished work of Christ.

Picture the scapegoat going into the wilderness with your sins. Ask God to help you believe that they are truly gone.

Because the sacrifice is finished, you can come near with confidence. Spend a few minutes in unhurried prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for fulfilling the Day of Atonement once for all.
- Ask for a true heart and full assurance as you draw near.
- Tell God what it means to you that your sins have been carried away.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 137 · WEEK 20

Psalm 51

True repentance, the heart beneath the sacrifice

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 51. After the Day of Atonement, this psalm shows the heart that stands behind the sacrifice. Read it as a prayer you could pray yourself, and notice how David asks for what the sacrifices could not give.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title of the psalm says it is "A Psalm of David, when Nathan the prophet went to him, after he had gone in to Bathsheba." It is David's prayer after his sin with Bathsheba and his murder of Uriah (2 Samuel 11 and 12). It is the greatest of the penitential psalms. The situation is particularly striking against the background of Leviticus. David's sin was deliberate, and the sacrifices of Leviticus 4 covered only unintentional sin. He has no sacrifice to bring. All he can do is throw himself on God's mercy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions" (v. 1).
2. "Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin!" (v. 2).
3. "Against you, you only, have I sinned and done what is evil in your sight" (v. 4).
4. "Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me" (v. 5).
5. "Purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean; wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow" (v. 7).
6. "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me" (v. 10).
7. "Cast me not away from your presence, and take not your Holy Spirit from me" (v. 11).

8 “For you will not delight in sacrifice, or I would give it; you will not be pleased with a burnt offering. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise” (vv. 16-17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 51 is the honest prayer of someone who has sinned deeply and knows it. David uses the vocabulary of Leviticus: “wash,” “cleanse,” “purge with hyssop” (the plant used in the cleansing rituals of Leviticus 14). But he cannot use the sacrifices, because there was no sacrifice for what he did. He is thrown back entirely on God’s mercy. His first word is “mercy,” and the basis of his appeal is not his own repentance but God’s “steadfast love,” the same word you read in Exodus 34:6.

The famous line, “Against you, you only, have I sinned,” does not mean that David’s sin did not hurt Bathsheba or Uriah. It means that all sin is ultimately against God. The wrong to people is real, but the deepest wrong is to the one who made them in his image. A person who truly sees his sin sees that it is first of all an offense against God.

Notice that David says his problem goes deeper than his actions. “I was brought forth in iniquity.” He is not excusing himself. He is saying that sin is not just something he did. It is something he is. This is why he prays, “Create in me a clean heart.” He does not ask for help to do better. He asks for a new creation. The word “create” is the same one used in Genesis 1:1. Only God can make a clean heart, as only God can make the world.

The ending is the center of the psalm. “You will not delight in sacrifice… the sacrifices of God are a broken spirit.” David is not rejecting the sacrificial system. In verse 19 he looks forward to right sacrifices being offered again. He is saying that sacrifices without a broken heart are empty. The system always depended on the heart of the worshiper, and God has always looked for it.

Psalm 51 is not a way to get around the Day of Atonement. It is the prayer of the person who knows what it means.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told a parable of a tax collector who beat his chest and prayed, “God, be merciful to me, a sinner!” and went home justified (Luke 18:13-14). Paul quotes Psalm 51:4 in Romans 3:4. The “clean heart” and “right spirit” echo God’s promise in Ezekiel 36:25-27. John says, “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1 John 1:9). In Christ, the broken heart finds the sacrifice it needs.

STEP 6

Application

Make this psalm your own prayer today. Read it aloud slowly, and let it lead you to confess whatever is on your heart.

If you carry guilt over something you have already confessed, remember the promise that God does not despise a broken and contrite heart.

Ask God to create in you the clean heart you cannot make yourself.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray the words of Psalm 51 in your own words, telling God what you need cleansed.
- Ask him to create a clean heart in you.
- Thank him for Jesus, in whom your confession is answered.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 138 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 17:1-19:37

Blood; sexual purity; love your neighbor

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 17:1-19:37. This reading includes the unit's anchor verse in chapter 17 and the well-known command to love your neighbor in chapter 19. Look for the connection between the sacrificial laws and the everyday ethical commands.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

With the Day of Atonement behind them, the book of Leviticus turns from how a holy God is approached to how a holy people live. Chapters 17 to 26 are often called the Holiness Code, because the refrain "You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy" (19:2) runs through them. Chapter 17 gives the reason for the prohibition on eating blood. Chapter 18 sets out sexual boundaries in contrast to Egypt and Canaan. Chapter 19 gathers a wide variety of commands for ordinary life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. All sacrifices must be brought to the tent of meeting, and not offered in the open field (17:1-9).
2. "For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it for you on the altar to make atonement for your souls, for it is the blood that makes atonement by the life" (17:11).
3. The prohibition of eating blood applies to sojourners too (17:10-14).
4. Israel is not to live as Egypt or Canaan do (18:3).
5. The laws of sexual conduct in chapter 18 are given because the nations around them "defiled" the land (18:24-30).
6. "You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy" (19:2).

7. The commands in chapter 19 include leaving the edges of the field for the poor (19:9-10), not stealing or lying (19:11), not withholding wages (19:13), and showing impartiality (19:15).

8. "You shall love your neighbor as yourself: I am the LORD" (19:18). "The stranger who sojourns with you shall be to you as the native among you, and you shall love him as yourself" (19:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Leviticus 17:11 is the key to the whole sacrificial system, and it is the anchor verse of this unit. It tells you why blood is used. It is not because blood is magical. It is because "the life of the flesh is in the blood." Blood represents life, and life is given on the altar in the place of the sinner's life. "I have given it for you." The sacrifice is not a human invention to placate an angry God. It is something God himself provided. He gave the blood on the altar for your atonement. The system is a gift.

It also teaches that atonement is costly. A life is given. Sin is not forgiven cheaply. This is not a cruel principle. It reflects how seriously God takes sin, and how seriously he takes the value of life.

The chapters that follow show what holy people look like. Notice that the same chapter that commands "You shall be holy" also commands leaving the edge of your field for the poor and paying a worker his wages at the end of each day. Holiness is not only about worship. It is about how you treat your neighbor, your employee, the deaf person, the blind person, and the foreigner. "You shall not curse the deaf or put a stumbling block before the blind" (19:14) is one of the sharpest examples. The vulnerable are protected because God is watching, and "I am the LORD" is repeated like a signature on each command.

The great command in verse 18, "You shall love your neighbor as yourself," is in the middle of this chapter. It is not a new idea in the New Testament. It is the center of the law. The love is practical: it shows itself in honesty, fairness, and generosity. And verse 34 extends it to the foreigner, with a reminder: "for you were strangers in the land of Egypt." The memory of their own redemption is the basis for how they treat others.

The chapters also remind us that the call to holiness comes after atonement. The people can be holy because their sins have been covered. Grace comes first, and the life of holiness follows.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus calls the command to love your neighbor the second greatest in the law (Matthew 22:39), and he explains it in the parable of the Good Samaritan (Luke 10:25-37). Paul says that "the whole law is fulfilled in one word: You shall love your neighbor as yourself" (Galatians 5:14). Peter quotes Leviticus 19:2 in 1 Peter 1:15-16. And Hebrews 9:22 says, "Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins," based on Leviticus 17:11. Christ is the one whose blood was given for us.

STEP 6

Application

Read Leviticus 17:11 several times. Consider what it means that God gave the blood for you.

Choose one command from chapter 19 that speaks to your life. Where could you practice it this week?

Think of someone in your community who is a stranger or an outsider. How could you show love to them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the life given for you.
- Ask him to make you holy as he is holy.
- Ask him to teach you to love your neighbor and the stranger.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 139 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 20:1-22:33

Holiness for priests and people; sacred things

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 20:1-22:33. These chapters continue the Holiness Code with penalties for serious sin, and with strict rules for the priests. Watch for the repeated reasons God gives for his commands.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 20 lists punishments for the offenses named in chapters 18 and 19, including child sacrifice, occult practices, and various sexual sins. Chapters 21 and 22 return to the priests and the sacred offerings, setting a higher standard for those who serve at the altar. The reading is demanding, and some of it is hard to take in. It is important to remember that these were laws for Israel as a nation under the old covenant, in a time and a place very different from ours.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The laws of chapter 20 are tied to the command, “Consecrate yourselves, and be holy, for I am the LORD your God” (20:7-8).
2. God says, “You shall be holy to me, for I the LORD am holy and have separated you from the peoples, that you should be mine” (20:26).
3. The punishments are severe, including death for some offenses, because the land itself will “vomit you out” if it is defiled (20:22).
4. The priests must avoid contact with the dead, except for close family, and are to be careful about marriage (21:1-15).
5. A priest with a physical defect may eat the holy food, but may not approach the altar (21:16-23).

6. Unclean priests may not eat the holy things until they are cleansed (22:1-9).
7. Offerings must be without blemish (22:17-25).
8. "You shall not profane my holy name, that I may be sanctified among the people of Israel. I am the LORD who sanctifies you" (22:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The refrain of this section is the double statement of God's character and God's work: "I am the LORD who sanctifies you." In chapter 20, the people are told to consecrate themselves and be holy. In 20:8 God says he is the one who makes them holy. In 21:8 and 22:32 he says it again. The call to holiness is not a demand to make yourself holy by effort. It is a call to live in line with what God has already done by choosing and setting apart his people.

The severity of the penalties is meant to be understood in context. In a nation where God lived among the people in the tabernacle, serious sin was not just a private matter. It threatened the whole community, because it defiled the land and the sanctuary. The penalties show how serious these sins were in God's eyes. They also show that Israel, as a theocracy, had a unique role. We should not read these laws as a model for modern governments. The New Testament shows that the church does not carry the sword, and that discipline in the church takes the form of rebuke and exclusion (1 Corinthians 5).

The restrictions on the priests are another picture of the holiness of God. A priest must be physically whole and ritually clean. He serves a God of perfect holiness, and the priest's own body is meant to reflect it. These regulations may seem harsh, especially the rule about physical defects. But they were not a judgment of a person's worth. A priest with a defect still ate the holy food and shared in the priestly benefits. The point was to picture the perfection of the one who would come to be the true priest.

And note again that offerings had to be without blemish. God deserves the best. It is a theme that runs from Cain and Abel to Malachi, where God rebukes the people for bringing blind and lame animals (Malachi 1:8). What we give to God shows what we think of him.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the priest without defect, "holy, innocent, unstained, separated from sinners" (Hebrews 7:26), and the lamb "without blemish or spot" (1 Peter 1:19). Paul says that Christ "gave himself up for her, that he might sanctify her" (Ephesians 5:25-26), and that "God has called us not for impurity, but in holiness" (1 Thessalonians 4:7). Peter calls believers "a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation" (1 Peter 2:9).

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the statement, “I am the LORD who sanctifies you.” Thank God that your holiness depends on his work.

Ask whether you are giving God your best, or what is left over.

Pray for the leaders of your church, that they would be examples of holiness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for setting you apart as his own.
- Ask him to help you give him your best.
- Thank him for Jesus, the perfect priest and spotless lamb.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

“You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy.”

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 140 · WEEK 20

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Leviticus 19:2 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

REST

Meditation

Leviticus 19:2 is the call that sums up the whole book. It is spoken to "all the congregation of the people of Israel," not just to the priests. Holiness is the vocation of every member of God's people.

"You shall be holy." The word means set apart, belonging to God. It has two sides. It means separation from what is sinful and common, and it means dedication to God. A holy person is not simply someone who avoids certain things. He is someone who belongs to God.

"For I the LORD your God am holy." This is the reason, and it is the whole reason. The command is not based on a rule but on a person. Israel is to be holy because their God is holy. The people of a holy God are to resemble him, as children resemble a father.

Notice the next verses in chapter 19. Holiness is not only about worship. It is about respect for parents, care for the poor, honesty in business, and love for your neighbor. To be holy is to reflect God's character in ordinary life.

For the Christian, Peter quotes the verse: “As he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct, since it is written, You shall be holy, for I am holy” (1 Peter 1:15-16). The call is the same, but the power is greater. In Christ you have been made holy, and the Holy Spirit lives in you to make you so.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you studied the heart of the book of Leviticus. You read about clean and unclean animals and the laws of skin disease, and you saw how the priest goes outside the camp to welcome a healed person back. You read the Day of Atonement, with the high priest entering the Most Holy Place and the two goats, one sacrificed and one sent away. You prayed Psalm 51, the prayer of a broken and contrite heart. You read the unit’s anchor verse, Leviticus 17:11, about the life in the blood. You read the Holiness Code, with the great command to love your neighbor as yourself, and the laws for priests and offerings. The week taught that atonement is costly and given by God, and that a forgiven people are called to be holy.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Day of Atonement showed sin being paid for and carried away. Which of these two pictures, the sacrificed goat or the scapegoat, speaks to you most today? Why?

Hebrews says that Jesus is both the high priest who enters the Most Holy Place and the sacrifice whose blood is offered. How does it change your sense of security to know that your priest and your sacrifice are the same person?

Leviticus 19 ties holiness to ordinary things like honest scales and care for the poor. Where in your daily life is God calling you to reflect his holiness more clearly?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that in Christ you have been set apart.

Ask him to help you love your neighbor as yourself this week.

Rest in his finished work today.

DAY 141 · WEEK 21

Leviticus 23:1-24:23

The feasts of the LORD; the lampstand and bread

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 23:1-24:23. Chapter 23 lays out the yearly calendar of Israel's festivals. Read it as a map of the year, and watch how often the word "rest" and the word "holy" appear.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The festivals of Israel mark the rhythm of the year around the agricultural seasons and, more importantly, around the great acts of God. They begin with the weekly Sabbath and run through Passover, Unleavened Bread, First Fruits, Weeks, Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, and Booths. Chapter 24 returns to the tabernacle with the lamp and the bread, and then describes an incident of blasphemy that leads to a ruling about justice. The chapters show that holiness extends to time as well as to space.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "These are the appointed feasts of the LORD, the holy convocations, which you shall proclaim at their appointed times" (23:2).
2. The weekly Sabbath comes first in the list (23:3).
3. The Passover is on the fourteenth day of the first month, followed by the seven days of Unleavened Bread (23:4-8).
4. The first sheaf of the harvest is waved before the LORD as First Fruits (23:9-14).
5. The Feast of Weeks comes fifty days after First Fruits, with a new grain offering (23:15-22).
6. The Feast of Trumpets and the Day of Atonement are in the seventh month (23:23-32).

7. The Feast of Booths lasts a week, and the people live in booths "that your generations may know that I made the people of Israel dwell in booths when I brought them out of the land of Egypt" (23:33-43).

8. A man who blasphemes the name is stoned, and the principle is stated: "You shall have the same rule for the sojourner and for the native" (24:10-23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The calendar in Leviticus 23 makes a point that is easy to miss: time itself belongs to God. Israel's year was not a series of random days. It was a story told in seasons. Passover recalled the night of the exodus. First Fruits recognized that the harvest belonged to the LORD. Weeks gave thanks for the grain. Trumpets and the Day of Atonement called the people to repentance. Booths celebrated God's provision in the wilderness. Every year, the people were reminded of who God is and what he has done.

The list begins with the Sabbath. Before the great festivals, there is the weekly rhythm of rest. The seventh day, each week, is a "holy convocation." It was the oldest feast, established at creation, and the foundation of the others. The point is that Israel's whole life is a pattern of work and rest, of effort and gratitude.

Notice how each festival is a response to something God did. They are not mainly about human achievement. Passover remembers rescue. Booths remembers the wilderness. First Fruits acknowledges that the harvest is a gift. The festivals teach the people to remember, and remembering is one of the main commands of the Old Testament. They are a form of teaching, put into the shape of a year.

The festivals also look forward. The harvest festivals point to a greater ingathering. The Day of Atonement points to a final cleansing. The feast of Booths, with its joy and its prospect of rest in the land, points to the day when God will live with his people forever.

The last part of chapter 24 includes the case of a man who cursed God's name. The point is that the name of the LORD is not to be treated lightly, and that the same law applies to everyone, native or sojourner. Justice does not play favorites.

STEP 5

Connection

The New Testament sees the festivals fulfilled in Christ. He is the Passover lamb (1 Corinthians 5:7). He is the "firstfruits" of those who have died (1 Corinthians 15:20). The Spirit came at Pentecost, the Feast of Weeks (Acts 2:1-4). Jesus stood in the temple at the Feast

of Booths and said, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37). Colossians 2:16-17 calls the festivals “a shadow of the things to come, but the substance belongs to Christ.” The church celebrates the Lord’s Day as a weekly remembrance of the resurrection.

STEP 6

Application

Think about your own calendar. Does it reflect what God has done, or does it only reflect your work?

Choose one rhythm this year, such as a weekly day of rest, or an annual time to remember God’s faithfulness, and plan for it.

Thank God for the way each of the festivals points to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to number your days.
- Thank him for Jesus, the Passover lamb and the firstfruits.
- Ask him to let the rhythm of your life be shaped by his goodness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

“He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty.”

PSALM 91:1

DAY 142 · WEEK 21

Leviticus 25:1-26:46

Sabbath year, Jubilee, blessings and curses

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 101 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 25:1-26:46. The first chapter describes a Sabbath year and a Jubilee, which are among the most radical ideas in the law. The second sets out the blessings and curses of the covenant. Read them together and notice how the second grows out of the first.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel was about to enter a land that God was giving them. Leviticus 25 and 26 explain how they were to live in it. The land belongs to God, and the people are his tenants. Every seventh year, the land was to rest. Every fiftieth year, the Jubilee, property returned to its original family and slaves went free. Chapter 26 then sets out what will happen if Israel obeys and if it does not. It is the close of the Holiness Code and the covenant section of Leviticus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When you come into the land that I give you, the land shall keep a Sabbath to the LORD" (25:2).
2. In the seventh year, the land is not to be sown or harvested, and God promises to provide enough in the sixth year (25:3-22).
3. The Jubilee is announced on the Day of Atonement: "And you shall consecrate the fiftieth year, and proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants" (25:9-10).
4. "The land shall not be sold in perpetuity, for the land is mine. For you are strangers and sojourners with me" (25:23).
5. A relative may "redeem" land or a person who has been sold because of poverty (25:25-28, 47-49).

6. Israelites are not to be treated as slaves, because "they are my servants, whom I brought out of the land of Egypt" (25:42).
7. Obedience will bring rain, harvest, peace, and God's presence: "I will walk among you and will be your God, and you shall be my people" (26:3-13).
8. Disobedience will lead to escalating discipline, ending in exile, and yet "I will remember my covenant with Jacob" (26:14-45).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Sabbath year and Jubilee are a vision of a society shaped by grace. The central claim is in 25:23: "The land is mine." Because God owns the land, no one can own it permanently. The Jubilee resets everything. Debts are cleared, land returns to the families who first received it, and slaves go free. It is a built-in safeguard against the growth of permanent poverty and inequality. No family could be locked out forever.

The reason behind this is the exodus. "They are my servants, whom I brought out of the land of Egypt." Because God redeemed Israel from slavery, Israelites are not to enslave each other. The memory of redemption shapes the economy.

The idea of a redeemer is also introduced here. A relative could buy back land or free a family member who had fallen into debt. This is the background for the story of Ruth and Boaz, and for the later use of the word redeemer for God himself. The redeemer is the one who pays the price to bring back what was lost.

Chapter 26 is the covenant's summary. It is a promise of blessing for faithfulness and a warning of discipline for rebellion. The blessing is rich: rain, harvest, safety, and God walking among them. But the curses are sobering: disease, defeat, famine, and finally exile. The warnings come in stages, with the repeated phrase "if you will not listen to me." God does not strike quickly. He disciplines and warns again, and gives space to turn.

The ending of chapter 26 is the most hopeful part. Even in exile, "I will remember my covenant." God says that he will not "break my covenant with them" (26:44). The covenant ends not with judgment but with a promise. This is the hope the prophets will cling to when the curses fall.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus began his ministry by reading from Isaiah 61, "to proclaim liberty to the captives… to proclaim the year of the LORD's favor" (Luke 4:18-19), which echoes the Jubilee. He is the true Redeemer, who bought us back from slavery to sin (Galatians 3:13; 1 Peter 1:18-19). Paul says

that the whole creation “will be set free from its bondage to corruption” (Romans 8:21). Hebrews 4:9 says that a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God.

STEP 6

Application

Consider the claim that everything you have belongs to God. Does that change how you hold your money, your home, or your plans?

Think about people who are trapped in debt or poverty. Is there a way you can act as a redeemer for someone in your life?

Rest in the promise that God remembers his covenant, even when you have failed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are holding too tightly, and ask him to teach you to hold it loosely.
- Thank him for the Jubilee Christ has brought.
- Thank him for remembering his covenant with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

“He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty.”

PSALM 91:1

DAY 143 · WEEK 21

Leviticus 27:1-34

Vows and devoted things, the conclusion

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 27:1-34. This is the last chapter of Leviticus, and it deals with vows and gifts to the sanctuary. It may seem like an odd ending, so read it as a final lesson about what it means to belong to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the great statements of covenant blessing and curse in chapter 26, the book ends with an appendix about vows. A person might promise himself, his family members, his animals, his house, or his land to the LORD. This chapter explains how to value those promises and how to redeem them. It closes the book with a practical reminder that gifts to God are real, and should be taken seriously.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The chapter begins with “When a man makes a special vow to the LORD involving the valuation of persons” (27:2).
2. A person’s value is set in shekels according to age and sex (27:3-7).
3. The poor could be valued according to what they were able to pay (27:8).
4. A person who dedicates an animal cannot substitute a better or worse one (27:10).
5. Someone who wants to redeem a house or field must add a fifth to its value (27:13, 15, 19).
6. The firstborn of animals already belongs to the LORD and cannot be vowed (27:26).
7. “Every devoted thing is most holy to the LORD” (27:28).

8 “All the tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land or of the fruit of the trees, is the LORD’s; it is holy to the LORD” (27:30). The book ends: “These are the commandments that the LORD commanded Moses for the people of Israel on Mount Sinai” (27:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The last chapter of Leviticus may seem like an anticlimax, but it ties a few themes together.

The first is the seriousness of promises to God. A vow was voluntary, but once made, it was binding. The chapter provides a way to redeem what was promised, but at a cost. The lesson is that words matter. When you make a promise to God, it is not a casual matter. Ecclesiastes 5:4-5 will say the same: “It is better that you should not vow than that you should vow and not pay.”

The second is that everything belongs to God. The firstborn animals are the LORD’s already. The tithe is the LORD’s. The land is the LORD’s, as chapter 25 said. Even the idea of giving something to God is a recognition that he owns it all. When you give, you are not paying God. You are acknowledging what is already his.

The third is the matter of valuation. The chapter assigns a price to persons, and that sounds strange to modern ears. It is not a statement of a person’s worth. It is the amount required to redeem a person who was dedicated to the sanctuary. Without it, someone dedicated to the LORD would have no way back to normal life.

Look at the larger shape of the book. Leviticus begins with the call from the tent of meeting, and the first words are, “If anyone of you brings an offering to the LORD.” It ends with the tithe and the devoted things. The book began with the offering and ends with the offerer. It shows what a holy people look like: they have been redeemed, they have been cleansed, and they give themselves to God.

The final verse is a reminder of where all this began. These commandments came on Mount Sinai. The book is not a collection of legal puzzles. It is the voice of the God who rescued Israel, speaking to the people he lives among.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus praised the widow who gave two small coins, because she gave “all she had to live on” (Mark 12:41-44). Paul urges Christians to give “not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver” (2 Corinthians 9:7). Peter says that you were redeemed “not with perishable things such as silver or gold” but with the precious blood of Christ (1 Peter 1:18-19). The price that redeems you is not a figure on a chart. It is the life of the Son.

STEP 6

Application

Think about any promise you have made to God that you have not kept. Bring it to him honestly.

Ask whether you treat what you have as yours or as his. Choose one concrete act of giving this week.

Thank God that the cost of your redemption has been paid by Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give God what is already his, and tell him what you want to give.
- Confess promises you have not kept.
- Thank him for the price paid for you in Jesus' blood.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."

PSALM 91:1

DAY 144 · WEEK 21

Psalm 50

I do not rebuke you for sacrifices, what God truly desires

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 50. After weeks of reading about sacrifices, this psalm puts a question to them. Read it as God's own voice, speaking in court, about what he truly wants from his people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 50 is a psalm of Asaph, one of the leaders of music in David's time. It is set in a courtroom. God summons the earth as a witness and speaks against his people. But the psalm does not say that the sacrifices were wrong. It says that Israel had begun to treat them as a way of handling God, as if he needed them. In the setting of the book of Leviticus, the psalm is a needed correction. It asks what the sacrifices were meant to do.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Mighty One, God the LORD, speaks and summons the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting" (v. 1).
2. "Out of Zion, the perfection of beauty, God shines forth" (v. 2).
3. God says he will speak to his people: "Gather to me my faithful ones, who made a covenant with me by sacrifice!" (v. 5).
4. "I do not rebuke you for your sacrifices; your burnt offerings are continually before me" (v. 8).
5. "If I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and its fullness are mine" (v. 12).
6. "Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving, and perform your vows to the Most High" (v. 14).

7. “Call upon me in the day of trouble; I will deliver you, and you shall glorify me” (v. 15).

8. To the wicked God says, “What right have you to recite my statutes or take my covenant on your lips?” (vv. 16-21). The psalm ends: “The one who offers thanksgiving as his sacrifice glorifies me” (v. 23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm does not criticize the sacrifices themselves. God says, “I do not rebuke you for your sacrifices.” What he corrects is a wrong idea about them. Some in Israel had come to think that the sacrifices fed God, or that they put him in their debt. God answers with a bit of humor: “If I were hungry, I would not tell you.” The cattle on a thousand hills are his. He does not need anything from us.

This is a necessary lesson for any religion. It is easy to think that our worship is a favor to God. The truth is the opposite. We need him, and he does not need us. Sacrifice does not make God our debtor. It is a way for us to receive from him.

What God wants, in place of a misunderstanding of sacrifice, is thanksgiving. “Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving.” The word is todah, and it also names a kind of peace offering, the thanksgiving offering of Leviticus 7:12. God wants his people to come with gratitude, to keep their vows, and to call on him in trouble. The relationship is one of dependence and thanks.

The second half of the psalm turns to people who go through the motions but live wickedly. They recite God’s laws, but they steal, commit adultery, and slander. God’s response is sharp. He has been silent, and they have assumed that he was like them, but now he will confront them. The warning is that formal religion without a changed life is dangerous.

The last verse puts the two halves together: “The one who offers thanksgiving as his sacrifice glorifies me; to one who orders his way rightly I will show the salvation of God.” Thanksgiving and a right way of life belong together. This is the heart behind the sacrifice.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul told the Athenians that God is not “served by human hands, as though he needed anything” (Acts 17:25). Hebrews 13:15 says, “Through him then let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God, that is, the fruit of lips that acknowledge his name.” Jesus said that the people honored him with their lips but their hearts were far away (Mark 7:6). Paul says that we are to “give thanks in all circumstances” (1 Thessalonians 5:18).

STEP 6

Application

Thank God today for five specific things, aloud. Treat it as an offering.

Ask whether your religion has become a way of handling God, rather than receiving from him.

Consider whether your life matches the words you say in worship.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he needs nothing from you yet receives your thanks.

Ask him to keep you from empty religion.

Ask him to let your life match your words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."

PSALM 91:1

DAY 145 · WEEK 21

Psalm 40:1-10

I delight to do your will, obedience better than sacrifice

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 40:1-10. Yesterday's psalm said that God wants thanksgiving more than sacrifices. Today's goes further, with a line that the New Testament applies to Christ. Read verses 6 to 8 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 40 is a psalm of David. The first ten verses are a song of thanksgiving for being rescued, and the rest of the psalm is a prayer for help. In the first part, David describes how God brought him out of a pit and put a new song in his mouth. Then, in the middle of the thanksgiving, he says something that seems surprising in a week spent reading about sacrifices: God has not desired sacrifice and offering.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I waited patiently for the LORD; he inclined to me and heard my cry" (v. 1).
2. "He drew me up from the pit of destruction, out of the miry bog, and set my feet upon a rock, making my steps secure" (v. 2).
3. "He put a new song in my mouth, a song of praise to our God. Many will see and fear, and put their trust in the LORD" (v. 3).
4. "Blessed is the man who makes the LORD his trust" (v. 4).
5. "Sacrifice and offering you have not desired, but you have given me an open ear. Burnt offering and sin offering you have not required" (v. 6).
6. "Then I said, Behold, I have come; in the scroll of the book it is written of me" (v. 7).
7. "I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart" (v. 8).

8 “I have told the glad news of deliverance in the great congregation; behold, I have not restrained my lips, O LORD” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a rescue story. David was in a pit, a bog, and he could not get out. He waited, and God lifted him up and put him on solid ground. The result is a new song. A person who has been rescued cannot help singing. And the song is for others, too: “Many will see and fear, and put their trust in the LORD.”

In verses 6 to 8, David reflects on what God wants in return. His answer echoes Psalm 50, Psalm 51, and the prophets. It is not mainly sacrifice. What God wants is an open ear and a willing heart. “You have given me an open ear.” The Hebrew phrase is literally “ears you have dug for me,” the picture of a God who opens the ears of his servant so he can hear and obey. “I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart.” It sounds like the promise of the new covenant in Jeremiah 31:33, where the law is written on the heart.

David does not say that the sacrifices are worthless. He says that they are not what God ultimately desires. The sacrifices were always meant to be accompanied by obedience, and obedience is what they were pointing to. “In the scroll of the book it is written of me” may mean that David sees his own kingship described in the law (Deuteronomy 17:18-20). But the language is larger than David could fill. He is a king who delights in God’s will, but not perfectly. His words reach beyond him to the perfect obedient servant.

The psalm ends the section with public witness. David does not keep his rescue to himself. He tells the “glad news” in the great congregation. A rescued person speaks. He declares God’s faithfulness and steadfast love, and does not hide it.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 10:5-10 quotes Psalm 40:6-8 and puts the words on the lips of Christ as he comes into the world: “Sacrifices and offerings you have not desired, but a body have you prepared for me.” Jesus is the one who fully delights to do God’s will. He says, “I have come to do your will, O God.” And by that will, “we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.” The sacrifices were always pointing to someone who would offer himself with a willing heart.

STEP 6

Application

Think back to a time when God lifted you out of a pit. Tell someone the story this week.

Ask the Lord for an open ear and a heart that delights in his will, not just one that obeys.

Read Hebrews 10:5-10 and thank Jesus for coming to do the Father's will on your behalf.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for drawing you out of the pit and setting your feet on a rock.

Ask him for an open ear and a heart that delights in his will.

Thank Jesus for coming to do the Father's will for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."

PSALM 91:1

DAY 146 · WEEK 21

Psalm 91

He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High, under God's wings

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 91. It is one of the best-loved psalms in the Bible, and it fits the end of a long study of the tabernacle. Read it as a description of what it means to live in God's presence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 91 has no title in the Hebrew, and its author is not named. Jewish tradition connects it with Moses, because the previous psalm, Psalm 90, is "A Prayer of Moses." The psalm is a song of trust. It speaks first about dwelling in the shelter of the Most High, then switches to a promise spoken to the believer, and ends with the voice of God himself. After the reading of the tabernacle, with the glory-cloud, the wings of the cherubim on the ark, and the presence of God among his people, this psalm applies those images to the believer's life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty" (v. 1).
2. "I will say to the LORD, My refuge and my fortress, my God, in whom I trust" (v. 2).
3. "He will cover you with his pinions, and under his wings you will find refuge; his faithfulness is a shield and buckler" (v. 4).
4. The believer need not fear "the terror of the night," "the arrow that flies by day," "the pestilence," or "the destruction that wastes at noonday" (vv. 5-6).
5. "A thousand may fall at your side, ten thousand at your right hand, but it will not come near you" (v. 7).

6. “For he will command his angels concerning you to guard you in all your ways” (v. 11).
7. “Because he holds fast to me in love, I will deliver him; I will protect him, because he knows my name” (v. 14).
8. “With long life I will satisfy him and show him my salvation” (v. 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The images of the psalm come from the tabernacle. “Shelter” and “shadow” recall the tent. “Under his wings” recalls the cherubim whose wings covered the mercy seat. The one who “dwells” in the shelter of the Most High is a person who lives in his presence. It is a picture of the believer as someone who has taken up residence in God’s house.

The promises that follow are bold. God will protect from plague, from enemies, and from danger. It is important to read them correctly. The Bible does not teach that believers will never suffer, and the psalm itself acknowledges that thousands may fall. The Bible also shows faithful people suffering, including Job, the prophets, and the apostles. The promise is not that nothing will touch you. It is that nothing will touch you apart from God. His presence is with you in the fire and the flood.

This is the lesson Satan missed when he quoted verses 11 and 12 to Jesus in the wilderness (Matthew 4:6). He took the promise of protection and tried to turn it into a license to test God. Jesus answered by quoting Deuteronomy: “You shall not put the LORD your God to the test.” The psalm is a promise to be trusted, not a tool for demanding proof.

The last three verses are spoken by God himself. “Because he holds fast to me in love, I will deliver him.” Notice the reason: not that the person is perfect, but that he holds fast. God’s love and the believer’s trust come together. “I will be with him in trouble; I will rescue him and honor him.” The deepest promise is the presence of God in trouble.

At the end, he says, “I will show him my salvation.” The word is yeshuah, the root of the name of Jesus. The psalm ends with the promise of salvation, which is finally a person.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus used the image of a hen gathering her chicks under her wings (Matthew 23:37). Paul says, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” and that nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:31-39). Hebrews 1:14 says that angels are “ministering spirits sent out to serve for the sake of those who are to inherit salvation.” Jesus, the one who knew the Father’s name perfectly, is our refuge, and in him we dwell.

STEP 6

Application

Say aloud verses 1 and 2 as a personal declaration. Consider what it means to “dwell” in God’s shelter, not just visit it.

Think of a fear you have. Place it before the Lord and ask him to be your refuge in it.

Do not use this psalm to demand something from God. Use it to trust him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you want to hold on to him in.
- Thank him for his presence in every trouble.
- Ask him to show you his salvation in Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

“He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty.”

PSALM 91:1

DAY 147 · WEEK 21

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 91:1 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."

PSALM 91:1

REST

Meditation

Psalm 91:1 is the opening of a song of trust, and a fitting summary of the whole unit. After weeks of reading about the tabernacle, the sacrifices, and the priests, this verse takes the images and puts them into the life of a believer.

"He who dwells." The verb means to sit, to stay, to make a home. It is not a short visit. The Old Testament tabernacle was a place where God dwelt among his people, and now the believer is invited to dwell in God.

"In the shelter of the Most High." The word "shelter" means a hiding place or a covering. "Most High" is a title that speaks of God's supreme power over all things. The one who hides in him hides in the greatest of all places.

“Will abide in the shadow of the Almighty.” A shadow is the place of protection from the heat of the sun. “Almighty” is the name Shaddai, the name by which God was known to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. The one who lives in God’s shelter is under the care of the God who keeps his promises.

For the Christian, this verse is fulfilled in Jesus. We are “in Christ.” We dwell in him, and he dwells in us (John 15:4-5). The shelter that the tabernacle pictured has been opened to all who believe.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Leviticus. You read the calendar of Israel’s festivals, and the Sabbath year and Jubilee with their promise of liberty. You saw the covenant’s blessings and curses and the promise that God remembers his covenant even in exile. You read the last chapter on vows and the tithe. In the Psalms, you prayed Psalm 50, where God says he wants thanksgiving and not empty sacrifice, Psalm 40, where David speaks of an open ear and a heart that delights in God’s will, and Psalm 91, a song of trust in the shelter of the Most High. The week taught that the festivals point to Christ, that God owns everything, and that the heart behind the sacrifice is what he wants.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Israel’s calendar was filled with feasts that taught the people to remember what God had done. What practices help you remember God’s work in your life?

Hebrews 10 places the words of Psalm 40:6-8 on the lips of Jesus. What does it mean to you that he delighted to do the Father’s will on your behalf?

Psalm 91 describes a life lived in the shelter of the Most High. What is one fear you want to bring into that shelter today? Write a short prayer about it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is your shelter and shadow.

Thank him for the festivals and psalms that point to Christ.

Rest in him today.

DAY 148 · WEEK 22

Psalm 92

It is good to give thanks to the LORD, the Sabbath psalm

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 92. It is the only psalm in the Psalter that is labeled "A Song for the Sabbath Day," and it ends this unit with praise. Read it slowly, and let it be a song of gratitude for everything you have read.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 92 is a song for the Sabbath. It was sung in the worship of Israel on the weekly day of rest. It is a psalm of thanksgiving that celebrates God's works and contrasts the end of the wicked with the flourishing of the righteous. It is a fitting close to a unit about God's dwelling with his people, because the picture at the end is of the righteous planted in the house of the LORD.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It is good to give thanks to the LORD, to sing praises to your name, O Most High" (v. 1).
2. The praise is "to declare your steadfast love in the morning, and your faithfulness by night" (v. 2).
3. "For you, O LORD, have made me glad by your work; at the works of your hands I sing for joy" (v. 4).
4. "How great are your works, O LORD! Your thoughts are very deep!" (v. 5).
5. "The stupid man cannot know; the fool cannot understand this: that though the wicked sprout like grass and all evildoers flourish, they are doomed to destruction forever" (vv. 6-7).
6. "But you, O LORD, are on high forever" (v. 8).

7. “The righteous flourish like the palm tree and grow like a cedar in Lebanon” (v. 12).
8. “They are planted in the house of the LORD; they flourish in the courts of our God. They still bear fruit in old age; they are ever full of sap and green, to declare that the LORD is upright” (vv. 13-15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a simple statement, “It is good to give thanks to the LORD.” Giving thanks is not a duty to be endured. It is good, a pleasure and a benefit. The psalm describes a day of rest filled with song and gratitude, with the harp and the lyre, morning and night.

The Sabbath is a day for remembering that God is the maker and doer. “You, O LORD, have made me glad by your work.” It is the work of God that makes the psalmist glad, not his own. The Sabbath is a day of rest because Israel’s life depends on what God has done. It is a weekly declaration that salvation is grace.

The middle of the psalm looks at the wicked. They may flourish for a time, “like grass,” but the grass withers. The psalmist wants us to see that apparent success is short-lived, and that God’s reign endures. “You, O LORD, are on high forever.” This is the steady center of the song.

The final image is one of the most beautiful in the Psalms. The righteous are like trees, a palm and a cedar, planted in the house of the LORD. A tree planted in a temple courtyard is sheltered, watered, and fed. And it keeps bearing fruit, even in old age. The picture is of a long, fruitful life lived near God.

This connects to the tabernacle. The tabernacle was filled with garden images, a lampstand shaped like a tree and curtains woven with fruit, because God’s dwelling place is the place where life flourishes. The psalm shows what happens to someone who is planted there. He grows. He does not dry up. And he lives to declare that the LORD is upright.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “The Sabbath was made for man” (Mark 2:27), and that he is “lord of the Sabbath.” He is also the vine in whom believers abide and bear much fruit (John 15:5). Psalm 1 describes the same flourishing tree. Paul says that believers are “filled with the fruit of righteousness that comes through Jesus Christ” (Philippians 1:11). Hebrews 4 promises a Sabbath rest for the people of God. And Revelation 22:2 describes the tree of life in the new Jerusalem, whose leaves are “for the healing of the nations.”

STEP 6

Application

Give thanks aloud for three works of God you have seen this week. Name them specifically.

Think about where you are planted. Are you connected to a local church, so that you can grow in the courts of the LORD?

Ask God to make you a person who keeps bearing fruit, even into old age.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for his work in you, in your own words.
- Ask him to plant you in his house and keep you fruitful.
- Tell him that he is upright and faithful.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 149 · WEEK 22

Review and Reflection

Unit 6 review, The Mosaic Covenant II, Tabernacle & Holiness

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it for you on the altar to make atonement for your souls, for it is the blood that makes atonement by the life."
>
> LEVITICUS 17:11

REST

Meditation

Leviticus 17:11 is the unit's anchor verse, and it is the clearest explanation in the Old Testament of why sacrifice works the way it does. Read it aloud once more before you continue.

"For the life of the flesh is in the blood." Blood is not a symbol of death only. It is the sign of life. When an animal's blood is shed, a life is given up. This is why the sacrifices were solemn. They were not a ritual meal but a taking of life.

"And I have given it for you on the altar." This is the surprise of the verse. The blood is something God has given. The sacrifice is not the people's attempt to reach God. It is God's gift to them. He gives the means by which they may be forgiven. The whole system rests on his initiative.

"To make atonement for your souls." Atonement is a covering or a ransom. The animal's life is accepted in place of the worshiper's. It is the substitute.

"For it is the blood that makes atonement by the life." The reason it works is that life is given for life. This verse answers the question of why anyone should approach God by blood. It is because the life of the substitute stands in the place of the sinner.

For the Christian, this verse finds its meaning in Jesus. He gave his life, and God gave him for us. "In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses" (Ephesians 1:7). "The blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin" (1 John 1:7).

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 6 you have read the second half of the book of Exodus and the whole of Leviticus. You began on Mount Sinai with God's instructions for the tabernacle. You saw the ark and the mercy seat, the table and the lampstand, the altar and the courtyard, and the clothing of the priests. You learned that the purpose of the whole project was stated in a single sentence: "Let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

You saw how quickly the people fell. While Moses was on the mountain, they made a golden calf, and he interceded for them. You heard him ask to see God's glory, and you heard God proclaim his name: merciful and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness. You watched the covenant renewed, the tabernacle built, and the glory of the LORD fill the tent. You prayed through Psalm 15 and Psalm 24, which ask who may stand in God's presence.

In Leviticus, you studied the five main offerings and what each one teaches about atonement, thanksgiving, and peace. You read how the priests were ordained, and how Nadab and Abihu died when they offered unauthorized fire. You studied the laws of clean and unclean, and you saw how the priest goes outside the camp to welcome the healed person back. The center of the unit was the Day of Atonement, with its blood on the mercy seat and its two goats, and you prayed Psalm 51 as the cry of a broken heart.

You read the Holiness Code and its great command to love your neighbor as yourself. You read the calendar of Israel's festivals, the Sabbath year, and the Jubilee, and the covenant's blessings and curses. You ended with the psalms: Psalm 50, which says that God wants thanksgiving more than empty sacrifice, Psalm 40, which speaks of an open ear and a delight in God's will, Psalm 91, a song of trust in God's shelter, and Psalm 92, a song for the Sabbath.

The unit taught that God is holy, that sin is costly, that atonement is God's gift, and that a forgiven people are called to be holy as he is holy.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the Tabernacle teaching us about how sinners can approach a holy God?

Think about the layout of the tent, from the gate to the Most Holy Place. Consider the altar, the basin, the veil, and the priest. Look back at Exodus 25:8 and Hebrews 9:11-12.

What does the sacrificial system reveal about the nature of atonement?

Review the five offerings in Leviticus 1 to 7. Look at the laying on of hands and the role of blood. Consider Leviticus 17:11 and what it means that God gave the blood.

What happens on the Day of Atonement, and how does it point to Christ?

Recall the high priest, the mercy seat, and the two goats from Leviticus 16. Read Hebrews 9:24-28 and 10:11-14. Ask what is different about Christ's sacrifice.

What does "be holy as I am holy" mean for the people of God?

Look back at Leviticus 19, where holiness includes love for neighbor, honest dealing, and care for the poor. Read 1 Peter 1:13-16. Ask how holiness is both a gift and a calling.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for teaching his people how to come near.

Thank him for Jesus, the blood on the altar for your atonement.

Ask him to keep the unit verse in front of you.